State Emergency Management Plan

Animal, Plant, Marine and Environmental Biosecurity Sub Plan

August 2024



VICTORIA State Government | Energy, Environment and Climate Action

Acknowledgements

We are committed to genuinely partner, and meaningfully engage, with Victoria's Traditional Owners and Aboriginal communities to support the protection of Country, the maintenance of spiritual and cultural practices and their broader aspirations in the 21st century and beyond.

We acknowledge and respect Victorian Traditional Owners as the original custodians of Victoria's land and waters, their unique ability to care for Country and deep spiritual connection to it.

We honour Elders past and present whose knowledge and wisdom has ensured the continuation of culture and traditional practices.

DEECA is committed to genuinely partnering with Victorian Traditional Owners and Victoria's Aboriginal community to progress their aspirations.



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Contents

1. Introduction 3
1.1 Purpose 3
1.2 Objective 4
1.3 Risk management standard 4
2. The biosecurity threat 5
2.1 Biosecurity risk environment 5
2.2 Biosecurity threats 6
3. Authorising environment 10
3.1 International 10
3.2 National 10
3.3 State 11
3.4 Legislation 12
4. Mitigation 13
4.1 Government 13
4.2 Individuals and Community 13
4.3 Traditional Owners 13
4.4 Industry 14
5. Biosecurity Planning 15
6. Preparedness 16
6.1 Victorian State, Regional and Municipal Planning Arrangements and interoperability 17
6.2 Regional Planning 17
6.3 Municipal Planning 17
7. Response 18
7.1 Investigations and alert 18
7.2 Biosecurity responses have distinct characteristics. 19
7.3 Incident Management System 22
7.4 Strategic policy and technical direction 29
7.5 Control 29
7.5.1 Zoonotic risk management in a biosecurity response 30
7.6 Planning 30
7.7 Operations 31
7.8 Logistics 32
7.9 Finance and administration 32

7.10 Public information 32
7.11 Emergency information and warnings 34
7.12 Liaison 35
7.13 Coordination 35
7.14 Stand down 36
7.15 Transfer of control 36
7.16 Relief function 36

8 Consequence management 36

9 Relief and recovery 38

9.1 Compensation and/or owner reimbursement costs – Valuation and compensation schemes 39

10 Capability 39

10.1 Human resources 39
10.2 Assistance from interstate 40
10.3 Mutual aid arrangements 40
10.4 Assistance from overseas 40
10.5 Assistance from industry and the community 40
10.6 Support agencies 41
10.7 Shared responsibility 41
10.8 Concurrent emergencies 42
10.9 Interoperability 42

11 Review and evaluation 43

12 Appendices 44

Appendix 12.1: Acts relevant to biosecurity in Victoria 44
Appendix 12.2 Glossary 46

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose

The Animal, Plant, Marine and Environmental Biosecurity Sub Plan ('the Plan') provides an overview of the current arrangements for the management of biosecurity emergencies—excluding human health emergencies and non-Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) wildlife emergencies—in Victoria and contains information on biosecurity mitigation, preparedness, response, relief, and recovery.

Environmental biosecurity is inclusive of pests and diseases that may impact terrestrial and freshwater environments and ecosystems. The Plan reflects an integrated approach and shared responsibility for biosecurity management between government, agencies, industries, businesses, Traditional Owners, and the community.

The Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action (DEECA) has developed this Plan to be consistent with national arrangements for biosecurity emergencies and with input from a range of other emergency management agencies. The Plan refers to a range of existing plans and documents but does not duplicate the information contained in these, instead providing directions to websites or other sources where the reader can obtain further information if required.

The Plan joins a suite of other hazard-specific plans as a sub plan of the State Emergency Management Plan (SEMP).

In accordance with the Victorian *Emergency Management Act 2013* (the Act), major biosecurity emergencies are classified as 'Class 2' emergencies. The SEMP identifies DEECA as the Control Agency in Victoria for biosecurity incidents covering:

- emergency animal disease outbreaks (including aquaculture)
- emergency plant pest or disease outbreaks (including bee pests or diseases)
- high risk invasive plant, animal and exotic marine pest incursions.

This Plan does not cover emergency management activities that DEECA delivers as a Support Agency, such as emergency animal welfare relief or agricultural loss and damage assessment in Class 1 emergency responses. These activities are described in the *Victorian Emergency Animal Welfare Plan* and the *Victorian Agricultural Response Plan*.

The Plan does not cover wildlife emergencies, which are defined within the SEMP and for which DEECA is the nominated Lead Agency. Response arrangements for these emergencies are defined within hazard specific wildlife response plans.

This is the second version of the Plan under the *Emergency Management Act 2013.* These arrangements are described at a point in time, and there may be changes resulting from reviews and evaluations of exercises, biosecurity emergencies and ongoing reform in the Victorian emergency management sector.

As the Control Agency for biosecurity emergencies, DEECA is responsible for the maintenance of this Plan. The Plan will be reviewed every three years, in accordance with the provisions of the Act. If the relevant preparer considers urgent updates are required, these may be made in accordance with s60AM of the Act. DEECA applies an integrated, unifying approach that aims to sustainably balance and optimise the health of people, animals, and ecosystems.

This Plan has been endorsed by the State Crisis and Resilience Council (SCRC) as a Sub Plan to the SEMP.

1.2 Objective

The objective of biosecurity is to minimise adverse impacts of pests and diseases on Australia's economy, environment, and the community, while facilitating trade. Effective biosecurity is essential to the ongoing health of Victoria's agricultural production, community, economy, and environment.

1.3 Risk management standard

The adoption of emergency risk management, and its underlying concept of risk, has helped communities and emergency managers move beyond the narrower concept of 'hazard' to 'risk'. Risk deals more broadly with the interaction of the exposure to hazard and specific vulnerabilities.

The risk management standard AS/NZS ISO 31000:2018 (the Standard) is applied to guide decision making where uncertainty exists. The Standard is adapted to support emergency management planning, which involves modifications to the context. This includes setting objectives that focus on community safety and wellbeing, rather than organisational objectives. Other key elements of the context include developing criteria that reflect community values and support robust assessments and results.

Emergency Plant Pests (EPPs, exotic pests and diseases not present in Victoria) and Emergency Animal Diseases (EADs) have been assessed as significant risks for Victoria in state level multi-hazard emergency risk assessment projects, such as Emergency Risks in Victoria (July 2020).



2. The biosecurity threat

Biosecurity is defined as the collective effort to prevent and manage the harms caused by plant and animal pests and diseases, and the impact they have on what we value most: our farms and parks, our pets and gardens, our native plants and animals, the cultural integrity of the landscape, the safety of our food, and the success of our industries.

Victoria's agriculture industry and the economy rely on protection by the biosecurity system. Biosecurity threats cause direct production and financial losses for farms through reduced crop and livestock yield and diminished output quality. Incursions can also result in loss of market access, increased costs to fulfill protocols, and reduced-price premiums.

Social impacts arising from biosecurity incursions can result at individual, household, and community levels.

Our natural environment is under continued threat from pests and diseases, which poses a significant risk to Victoria's unique ecology. Exotic and established pests and diseases are recognised as a major driver of the decline in ecosystems and wildlife and are responsible for over 80 percent of mammal extinctions.

Biosecurity threats are also a risk to human health. At least 75 percent of the new human infectious diseases that have emerged since the 1970s have originated from animal diseases, otherwise known as zoonotic diseases.

A strong biosecurity system is also crucial to preserving the important cultural heritage of Traditional Owners. Many indigenous flora and fauna species hold cultural importance as totems for Aboriginal peoples. Consequently, any harm inflicted upon indigenous plants, animals and their habitats by pests and diseases and their management directly impacts on the cultural values of Aboriginal peoples.

The biosecurity system ultimately plays an important role in protecting and preserving vital aspects of Victoria's way of life, including living standards, community and social cohesion, security, and safety. For example, plant pests and diseases can impair the visual appeal of our landscapes and the quality of social amenity in our communities. Severe animal disease outbreaks can have devastating impacts on community wellbeing, tourism, and recreational use of the landscape, particularly in rural and regional areas.

2.1 Biosecurity risk environment

Key drivers of risk (See Figure 1) include the increased movement of people, goods and vessels into Victoria, climate change, criminal activities such as international smuggling, and changes to land use and industry practices. These challenges overlay existing inherent risks of biological agents which can be susceptible to mutations and recombination that enable pests and diseases to evolve into more pathogenic variants.



Figure 1: Key drivers of risk in a changing environment

2.2 Biosecurity threats

There are hundreds of pest and disease threats recognised for Victoria and Australia that would necessitate an investigation and emergency response if detected. Examples of the significant pest and disease threats are:

African swine fever (ASF): ASF is a contagious viral disease of domestic and feral pigs. The virus is spread directly between pigs, by consumption of infected meat, by bites of some insects, and/or from contaminated feed, water, clothing, footwear, vehicles, and equipment. Since ASF was detected in China in 2018 it has spread rapidly throughout southeast Asia and parts of Timor Leste, Indonesia, and Papua New Guinea. If introduced into Australia, ASF could have a significant impact on pig health and production and have major impacts on the domestic pork industry and regional economies. There is no registered vaccine for ASF and the disease kills about 80 percent of the pigs it infects. Testing of pork products intercepted at international mail centres in Australia has detected ASF viral fragments in more than 20 percent of samples. A legislated ban on the feeding of meat products to pigs aims to reduce the risk of infected product being fed to pigs however, these seizures of pork products containing ASF virus fragments reinforces the ongoing risk faced by Australia, the need for sound preparedness and the importance of compliance with Australia's strict biosecurity requirements. A 2021 rapid 'structured expert judgement' exercise by the Centre of Excellence for Biosecurity Risk Analysis estimated there is a 21% (range 5%-39%) probability of an outbreak in the next five years. ABARES estimated the economic cost of a small scale-outbreak in domestic pigs followed by eradication of the disease to be between $117 million and $263 million[1].



Image: sourced from www.afrivip.org/sites/default/files/ASF/diagnosis.html

Avian influenzas: Low pathogenic avian influenza (LPAI) viruses circulate in wild birds without causing disease. On occasion the virus spills over into domestic poultry populations and mutates into high pathogenicity avian influenza (HPAI) strains causing severe disease and high levels of mortality. In a change from this typical pattern of infection, a new HPAI variant, known as HPAI H5N1 clade 2.3.4.4b, has been spreading globally since 2020 through wild birds, resulting in significant mortalities of both wild birds and poultry, as well as marine and terrestrial mammals. A small number of human infections have been reported globally for HPAI clade 2.3.4.4b. Oceania is the only remaining region where the HPAI clade 2.3.4.4b virus has not been detected.

Outbreaks of high pathogenicity avian influenza (not HPAI clade 2.3.4.4b) have occurred on poultry farms in Victoria in 1976, 1985, 1992, 2019 (small backyard flock), 2020 and 2024. All bird samples submitted to the state animal health laboratory are screened for avian influenza virus and annual wild bird testing also provides valuable surveillance to monitor the types of avian influenza virus circulating in Victoria.



Image: courtesy of Megan Scott

[1] Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences, 2023 (ABARES)

Foot-and-mouth disease (FMD): FMD is a highly contagious viral disease affecting a wide range of livestock species such as cattle, sheep, goats, deer, and pigs. Vehicles, equipment, people, and footwear/clothing can spread the disease. Control measures include strict movement restrictions, depopulation of infected properties and decontamination of sites. Consequences of an outbreak are significant to not only livestock and agricultural industries but also broader businesses and economies. A 2022 ABARES report stated that the economic impact of a large multi-state outbreak of FMD in Australia could be as high as $80 billion over 10 years[2]. Australia relies heavily upon exports and international market access for livestock products is lost immediately upon detection of FMD. These markets can take many years to regain or may be lost permanently, causing significant economic loss. The United Kingdom experienced a FMD outbreak in 2001 that cost approximately AUD$19 billion to its economy, required 11 months to contain the outbreak and involved the destruction of six million animals. A recent incursion in Indonesia has increased the risk of an outbreak of FMD. A rapid 'structured expert judgement' exercise by the Centre of Excellence for Biosecurity Risk Analysis estimated there is a probability of an outbreak of an outbreak in Australia of 11.6 percent over the next five years (increased from 9 percent in 2021).



Image: courtesy of Megan Scott

Hendra virus (HeV): HeV is a disease transmitted to horses by flying-foxes. On rare occasions, infected horses have transmitted disease to humans with fatal consequences. The mortality rate in horses is 80 percent and in humans four of seven confirmed cases have died (mortality rate of ~57 percent). There has never been a confirmed clinical case of Hendra virus infection in any species in Victoria to date, however henipavirus (Hendra virus genotype 2) has been detected in Victorian flying-foxes. The frequent movement of horses from known Hendra-areas (Queensland and northern NSW) and movement of flying-foxes presents ongoing risks of Hendra virus transmission into Victoria**.** Incidents require a close collaboration between animal health and public health response agencies.



Image: courtesy of abc.net.au

[2] Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences, 2022 (ABARES)

Lumpy skin disease: Lumpy skin disease is a viral disease of cattle and buffalo which causes firm, raised nodules around the skin of the head, neck and body. Animals can become infected through biting insects or close contact with contaminated equipment and clothing for example.
The disease would have significant and far-reaching impacts should there be an incursion in Australia. There would be considerable economic losses with restrictions being placed on both domestic and international markets. In 2022, detections of both FMD and lumpy skin disease in Indonesia significantly increased Australia's risk of an EAD incursion. At the time, the combined probability of a major EAD incursion into Australia in the next five years was estimated to be 56 percent which includes 28 percent for lumpy skin disease.



Image: courtesy of Animal Health Australia

Brown marmorated stink bug (BMSB) Brown marmorated stink bug (BMSB) is a plant sucking bug which presents a significant biosecurity risk to Australia due to its hitch-hiking tendencies, broad host range and highly mobile nature. At risk is over 300 agricultural, nursery and ornamental plant hosts. Feeding damage on fruit make the fruit unmarketable as a fresh product, and in severe cases can render the crop unusable for processed products. Piercing wounds also provide a pathway for disease to enter the host plant. The ability of BMSB to feed on such a wide range of hosts makes it difficult to manage across landscapes. BMSB are dormant in cooler winter temperatures where large numbers will seek shelter in man-made structures, emerging only as the temperature increases in spring. This aggregating ability helps BMSB to spread rapidly outside its native range by sheltering in shipping containers, machinery, packing crates, vehicles and luggage which are transported across the globe. Goods arriving in Australia in September to April, coinciding with late autumn and winter in the Northern Hemisphere, are high risk for BMSB. Adults will fly long distances in search of food. In large numbers, BMSB becomes a considerable nuisance invading dwellings and producing a foul smell when disturbed. At stake is Victoria's horticulture industry which has a gross value of $3.2 billion[3].



Image: Agriculture Victoria

Khapra beetle: Khapra beetle is number two on Australia's National Priority Plant Pest list. Khapra beetle prefers grains, particularly wheat, but has been recorded on over 100 commodities. The larval stages infest the stored produce which taint the quality of commodity rendering it unfit for consumption. Contact with the larvae and skin moults can cause skin irritation and ingesting contaminated food can cause gastro-intestinal inflammation or a severe allergic reaction. The larvae can survive in stored food and packaging material in conditions with little moisture for extended periods of time. The preference for hiding in cracks and crevices makes khapra beetle difficult to locate and enables them to be easily, and unintentionally, transported via movement of people and goods around the world. Khapra beetle has been detected in the food-less consignments of packaging material associated with industrial and domestic equipment/supplies. Economic loss of valuable grain or other domestic or export products is a



Image: Agriculture Victoria

[3] Agriculture Victoria – Victorian Horticultural Industry Factsheet – January 2023

major consideration given the gross value of Victoria's grain production was $3.6 billion in 2020-21[4]. The establishment of khapra beetle in Australia would see production costs increase for prevention and treatment measures. It is not easily controlled with insecticides, nor other nonchemical methods, that are usually effective against other similar pests. It is estimated that a widespread incursion of khapra beetle could cost the Australian $15.5 billion over 20 years[5] .

Red Imported Fire Ant (RIFA): RIFA is a highly aggressive ant species known for their painful sting. RIFA presents a serious threat to agricultural production, native ant species and the environment, significantly impact on amenity use in backyards, playgrounds, parks and gardens, damage infrastructure and can potentially be fatal to young children, pets and the elderly. RIFA has been detected on multiple occasions in Australia, and thus far either successfully eradicated or under current eradication programs. The most significant eradication response is currently being delivered in South-East Queensland since 2001. In 2021, a benefit cost analysis by the Central Queensland University estimated that in the absence of the eradication program annual costs of RIFA impacts would exceed $1 billion within 15 years[6]. RIFA has been detected previously in Victoria in shipments from Brisbane, USA and China. Most recently, in February 2023, a RIFA queen was found at Thomastown in Melbourne in a consignment of potted plants from Queensland. Early intervention on each occasion successfully eliminated the pest. RIFA is just one example of exotic invasive ants that pose similar risks to Australia.



Image: RIFA bites can cause strong reactions in humans. Image courtesy of Murray S Blum, University of Georgia.Buwood.org.

Xylella fastidiosa: This exotic bacterial pest has been identified as the number one threat on the National Priority Plant Pest list in Australia and listed on the National Priority List of Exotic Environmental Pests, Weeds, and Diseases due to its potential to significantly impact a broad range of commercial (production), ornamental and native species. This bacterium is transmitted by insects that feed on the plant's xylem and causes plant death through stopping water movement. There are no chemical treatments to manage *X. fastidiosa*, and therefore infected trees must be destroyed, while spread is managed by suppressing the insect vectors. In Australia, the potential impact on the Australian horticulture industry due to this disease has been estimated to be between AU$1.2 billion and AU$8.9 billion over 50 years[7] while the potential impacts on the wine sector have been estimated between $2.8 billion and $7.9 billion over 50 years[8].



Image: Leaf scorch symptoms produced by Xylella fastidiosa infection. Courtesy of John Hartman, University of Kentucky, Bugwood.org.

[4] ABS Australian Bureau of Statistics Value of agricultural commodities produced - Australia, states and territories 2021-22

[5] Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry

[6] Star,M., Rolfe, J. 2021. *Assessing the Impacts of the Red Imported Fire Ant* Report for Biosecurity Qld, Department of Agriculture and Fisheries

[7] Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Protecting Australia's horticultural industries from disease

[8] DAFF, Economic impacts of Xylella fastidiosa on the Australian wine grape and wine-making industries

3. Authorising environment

Australia has well-developed emergency biosecurity arrangements implemented through state and federal legislation and arrangements.

3.1 International

Australia is a signatory to a range of international agreements that impact biosecurity obligations and operational responses. These include agreements and standards that apply to Australia as a member of the World Trade Organisation, the World Organisation for Animal Health, formerly known as the Office International des Epizooties (OIE) and the International Plant Protection Convention. Resumption of trade in agricultural products after an outbreak may be dependent on demonstrating compliance with these standards and will be expected to come under significant scrutiny from trading partners.

3.2 National

The Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity (IGAB) is a domestic agreement between all Australian governments, that sets out commitments, outline agreed national goals and objectives and clarify roles, responsibilities, and governance arrangements. Under the IGAB, the National Biosecurity Committee and associated arrangements provides national, strategic management and oversight of the national biosecurity system, to assist in addressing biosecurity threats, and oversees operation of the agreement, facilitating intergovernmental relationships.

There are also three key response agreements to which Victoria is a signatory. These outline commitments made by signatories, and guide the decision making process and cost sharing of responses to emergency pests and diseases:

- Emergency Animal Disease Response Agreement (EADRA)
- Emergency Plant Pest Response Deed (EPPRD)
- National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement (NEBRA)

For the EADRA and EPPRD, national decision making brings together all affected parties for that response (Commonwealth Government, all state/territory governments, and signatory affected Industry Bodies). These parties also contribute to the cost sharing for response activities. Where the biosecurity incidents relate to an exotic emergency environmental pest or disease of national significance then the NEBRA, to which the Commonwealth and all state/territory governments are signatories, may be used.

Operating outside of, or inconsistent with, these agreements may have consequences in terms of Victoria's ability to recoup costs.

Animal Health Australia (EADRA), Plant Health Australia (EPPRD) and the Australian Government Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (DAFF) are the custodians of the agreements. Animal Health Australia (AHA) and Plant Health Australia (PHA) are independent national bodies in Australia whose members include the Commonwealth, State and Territory governments, animal or plant industries, service providers and associate members. These bodies manage the development and review of underpinning plans such as AUSVETPLAN (EADRA) and PLANTPLAN (EPPRD), which detail the nationally agreed approaches for the response to different emergency pests and diseases. Refer to the relevant websites[9,10,11] for further details regarding the national response and deed agreements.

Under these arrangements, in the event of a biosecurity incursion in Victoria, the Victorian representative is responsible for briefing the relevant Consultative Committee and providing a response plan and budget for recommendation.

[9] https://www.animalhealthaustralia.com.au/what-we-do/emergency-animal-disease/ead-response-agreement/

[10] https://www.planthealthaustralia.com.au/biosecurity/emergency-plant-pest-response-deed/

[11] https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity/emergency/nebra

The relevant Consultative Committee is responsible for recommending to the National Management Group (NMG)[12] whether a response should proceed, based on an assessment of whether the pest, weed or disease meets the EADRA, EPPRD or NEBRA criteria, the technical feasibility of eradication, and whether eradication would be cost-beneficial (Figure 2).

The NMG is responsible for endorsing the response plans and associated budgets, which binds parties to financially contribute to the response through defined cost-sharing arrangements.

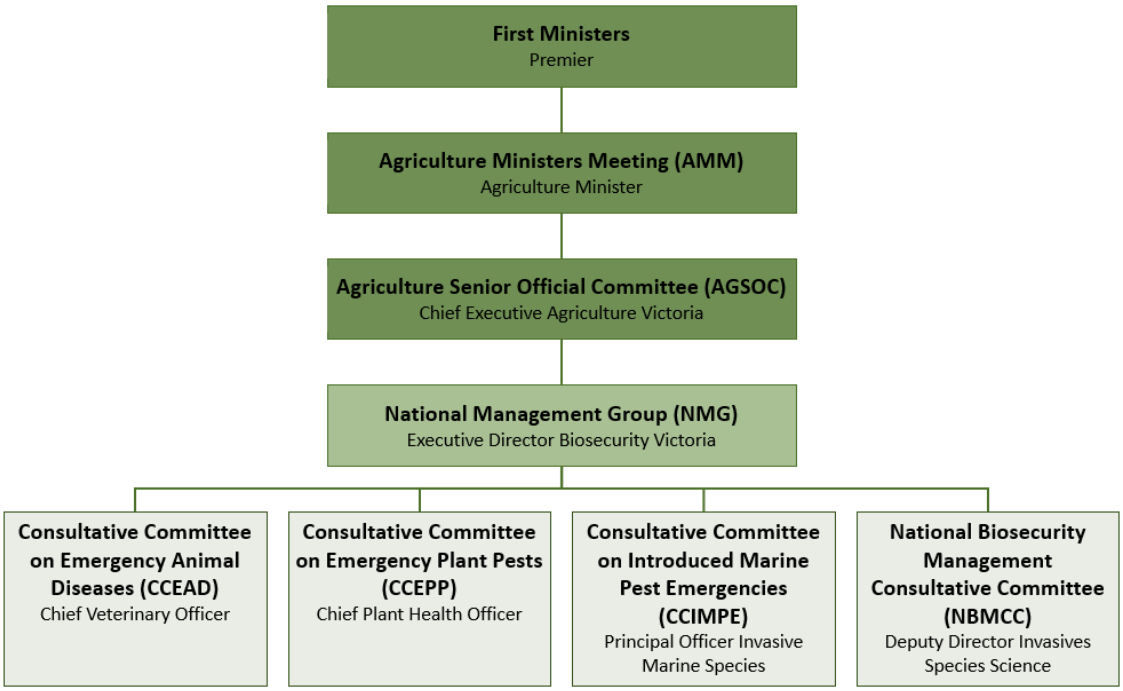


Figure 2: National Biosecurity Framework for emergencies[13], including Victorian representatives

3.3 State

Under the *Emergency Management Act (2013*), the Emergency Management Commissioner has legislated response coordination responsibilities, ensuring effective control arrangements are in place, consequence management and recovery coordination.

In Victoria, the State Emergency Management Plan outlines the Victorian arrangements for the mitigation of, response to and recovery from emergencies, and specifies the roles and responsibilities of agencies in relation to emergency management[14]. Whereas DEECA is the Control Agency for biosecurity emergencies in Victoria.

DEECA, as the Control Agency, will implement its biosecurity emergency management arrangements (including this Plan) to mitigate biosecurity risks, plan, prepare and respond effectively to the emergency in line with state, national and international arrangements.

As a Control Agency, DEECA is responsible for:

- Providing Victoria's affected industries and communities with advice about biosecurity risks and mitigation strategies, as well as education materials on the state's biosecurity emergency management arrangements.
- Partnering with Traditional Owners to share information and advice about biosecurity risk, as well as the state's biosecurity emergency management arrangements.

[12] For responses conducted under NEBRA, the NMG is referred to as the National Biosecurity Management Group (NBMG)

[13] Emergency response standing consultative committees accurate as of early 2024. Additional response-specific consultative committees exist and new standing consultative committees may be formed.

[14] https://www.emv.vic.gov.au/responsibilities/state-emergency-management-plan-semp/roles-and-responsibilities/role-statements/role-statement-department-of-energy-environment-and-climate-action

- Advising the Emergency Management Commissioner on the existence of, or potential for, a biosecurity emergency in Victoria.
- Working with organisations at the source of a biosecurity emergency to develop and oversee the implementation of effective incident response plans, including strategies to contain and eradicate active biosecurity threats.
- Undertaking the control activities and eradication activities associated with the biosecurity incursion.
- Working with support agencies, Victoria Police, other government departments and private businesses to undertake operational response activities.
- Supporting the Emergency Management Commissioner through provision of regular situation updates and expert biosecurity advice.
- Providing information and strategic advice to the Premier and Cabinet (including any Cabinet subcommittees), and SCRC on whole-of-government response activities for biosecurity emergencies.

3.4 Legislation

The following legislation, while not exhaustive, represents the principal foundation for biosecurity management in Victoria, although other Acts and regulations may be used depending on the situation.

Biosecurity Act 2015 (Commonwealth)

Catchment and Land Protection Act 1994

Emergency Management Act 1986 and Emergency Management Act 2013

Fisheries Act 1995

Livestock Disease Control Act 1994

Livestock Management Act 2020

Plant Biosecurity Act 2010

A complete list of relevant legislation is provided in **Appendix 12.1**.

This legislation provides a broad range of powers to biosecurity staff to facilitate the effective management of pest, disease and weed incidents. Some examples of the powers that are distinct from other emergencies include:

- Designating Restricted and Control Areas where specific biosecurity requirements and movement controls can be implemented.
- Application of Infested Lands Notices and Quarantine Notices on premises where a biosecurity risk is known to occur, which restricts movement on and off the premise, and directs for risk mitigation activities to be carried out.
- Requiring industry and members of the public to report detections of specific pests and diseases to the government within specified timeframes.
- Requiring businesses to undertake pest or disease control activities where a biosecurity risk is known to occur. This may include requiring the destruction of property, including livestock, plants, plant products and packaging.

Traditional Owners: DEECA is committed to supporting Traditional Owner self-determination, as outlined in the Victorian Aboriginal Affairs Framework 2018-2023 and Self-Determination Reform Framework (2019). In addition to these whole-of-government policies, Government also has legal obligations to support Traditional Owners' rights and responsibilities, outlined in the *Traditional Owner Settlement Act 2010* (Vic), *the Aboriginal Heritage Act 2006* (Vic), *the Native Title Act 1993* (Cwth) *and the Charter of Human Rights and Responsibilities Act 2006* (Vic).

4. Mitigation

4.1 Government

The Commonwealth Government has responsibility for pre-border and border surveillance and quarantine activities, limiting the potential for pests and diseases to enter and establish in Australia in line with Australia's appropriate level of protection. Similarly, Victoria sets entry conditions for products entering the state from elsewhere in Australia based on biosecurity risks. In Victoria, a range of agencies have identified responsibilities for mitigation activities. These are outlined in table 8 of the SEMP.

Victoria conducts a range of surveillance programs for animal, plant and marine pests and diseases to detect new incursions before they become widely established, increasing the chance of successful eradication or containment and demonstration of state or area freedom to support market access. Victoria provides information on biosecurity that builds awareness and engagement across business, industry, and the wider community with respect to biosecurity.

Victoria's favourable pest and disease status is primarily maintained by the ongoing regulation of activities that have the potential to cause a pest or disease outbreak. These regulations are wide-ranging and apply to activities such as the import, keeping, movement and sale of plants, animals, and their products (e.g. milk, fruit, eggs). Wherever possible, DEECA works with the community and industry to encourage voluntary compliance and industry co-regulation.

Where DEECA identifies non-compliance with biosecurity legislation, it will take enforcement action proportionate to the risk posed by the non-compliance. Penalties for failing to comply with biosecurity regulations can be severe and include imprisonment.

4.2 Individuals and Community

Building safer and more resilient communities is a shared responsibility of all Victorians. Community members can play a key role in mitigating biosecurity risks by educating themselves on what is 'normal' in their environment, thereby recognising and reporting any irregularities they notice in the flora and fauna of their area. Early detection is critical to minimising the size of a response. Some pests, diseases and weeds can spread very rapidly before they are detected.

State legislation requires all those who suspect or know of the presence of specified pests and diseases to report that knowledge to the relevant authorities.

Any suspected detections of plant or bee pests and diseases are reported through the **Exotic Plant Pest Hotline – 1800 084 881.** Plant pests can also be reported via online reporting forms while bee pests can be reported via email honeybee.biosecurity@agriculture.vic.gov.au.

Suspected detections of Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) are reported to the **Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888** (sick livestock, poultry, wildlife, and aquatic animals).

Reports of invasive animal or plant species are reported to the **DEECA Customer Contact Centre on 136 186** or via the relevant online reporting forms.

Marine pests can be reported via the relevant online form

Further information can be obtained via https://agriculture.vic.gov.au/biosecurity.

4.3 Traditional Owners

DEECA will work in partnership with Traditional Owners to ensure biosecurity risks are understood and will support Traditional Owners to use cultural practices to manage and mitigate those risks. Mitigation can combine traditional Aboriginal practices like the use of fire and listening to Country with the latest advice from academics, botanists, ecologists, and farmers to ensure Country stays healthy.

4.4 Industry

Animals Health Australia (AHA) and Plant Health Australia (PHA) work with the Commonwealth, state and territory governments and member industries to support the delivery of biosecurity outcomes. Industry biosecurity plans developed and owned by industry associations on behalf of their members outline how growers and producers, industry associations and government will collectively minimise the impact of emergency pests and diseases on their industry.

Industry organisations may also provide industry specific farm-biosecurity plans that can be readily adopted and implemented on-farm by growers and producers. Farm or business biosecurity management plans provide a way for producers to record how they are managing biosecurity risks including preventing the introduction of pests, disease, weeds, and contaminants to their property, spreading around their property, or spreading from their property. Biosecurity planning is also important for businesses involved in the agricultural sector to minimise their potential to spread pests and diseases from one property to another. Producers are strongly encouraged by industry, national and state peak bodies to develop these plans and they are often an integral part of farm assurance programs such as the Livestock Production Assurance Program for the red meat industry.

In some industry sectors there are well-established traceability systems (e. g., electronic animal identification and Property Identification Codes) that help track animal or plant movements and facilitate timely and effective response by allowing rapid confirmation of movements that may have spread the pest or disease.

DEECA works with industry and community stakeholders to ensure biosecurity risks are understood. DEECA also supports stakeholders to adopt practices to manage and mitigate those risks and to build resilience. These activities include creation of formal or informal collaborations and partnerships to build capacity and capability to undertake surveillance, monitoring activities and enhance early detection of outbreaks and targeted stakeholder engagement and strategic communication to increase understanding of biosecurity risks, appropriate measures and reporting mechanisms.

General information regarding biosecurity including the latest updates/alerts, diagnostic services and pest or disease information can be found at https://agriculture.vic.gov.au/biosecurity

5. Biosecurity Planning

There is a robust process in place to undertake biosecurity planning to support risk identification and mitigation, management of emergency response and business continuity. This process is delivered at the farm, region, state, national and international levels. Biosecurity planning includes:

- Commodity and pest/disease-specific import risk analysis to determine national border restrictions.
- Industry biosecurity planning to identify priority pest threats and recommended mitigation measures to be driven by industry.
- Contingency planning and strategy development for priority pests and diseases that inform and direct emergency response operations.
- Participating in the development and maintenance of nationally agreed response management procedures such as PLANTPLAN, AUSVETPLAN and the Emergency Marine Pest Plan (EMPPLAN).

Development and maintenance of farm or business biosecurity plans is implemented at the business level to mitigate the introduction and establishment of pest, diseases, and weeds.

Victoria contributes to the development and implementation of these plans through well-established national arrangements and linkages with state-based industry bodies.

The national documents can be accessed through DAFF[15], AHA[16] and PHA[17] websites.

DEECA also develops and maintains plans in relation to managing biosecurity emergencies, which are reviewed periodically. These include the Victorian State Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) Response Plan. DEECA plans align to those produced at the national level and ensure risk assessments and available biosecurity measures align to Victoria's environment, industries and legislation. In addition, DEECA regularly engages in cross sector consultation with other government departments and agencies to consider cross portfolio risks, mitigation methods and different sector strategies and plans. Biosecurity planning also needs to consider aspects such as psychosocial, mental health and wellbeing of all parties involved even though such aspects are not directly related.

[15] www.agriculture.gov.au

[16] https://animalhealthaustralia.com.au/

[17] https://www.planthealthaustralia.com.au/

6. Preparedness

The National Biosecurity Committee (NBC), established under the Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity (IGAB), brings together all Australian governments in recognition that biosecurity is a shared responsibility and that a national, strategic approach to biosecurity threats and intergovernmental cooperation is required to mitigate and prepare for these threats.

The NBC is supported by four sectoral committees and a communications and engagement network (Figure 3). These provide policy, technical and scientific advice on matters affecting their sector, covering all pests and disease risks to the terrestrial and aquatic (inland water and marine) animals and plants, and the environment. The NBC may form expert groups and short-term task specific groups from time to time to provide advice and deliver key initiatives.

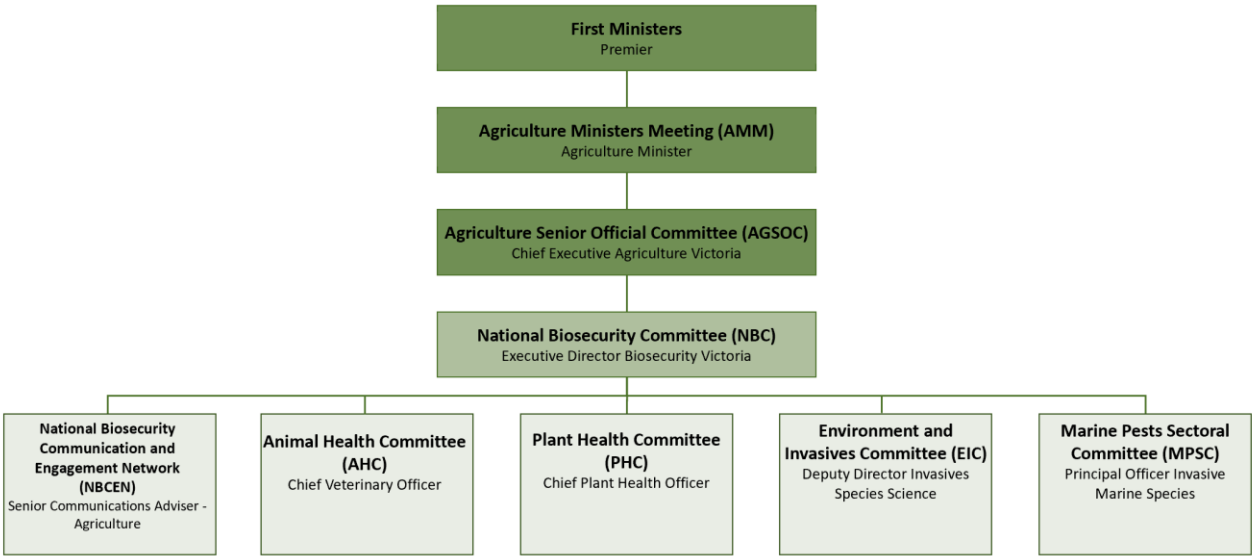


Figure 3. National Biosecurity Framework for preparedness, including the Victorian representatives

Preparing for biosecurity emergencies includes developing arrangements to ensure that, should a pest or disease outbreak occur, all the resources and services needed to respond can be efficiently mobilised and deployed. Preparedness activities include:

- identifying and assessing the risk (i. e., Australia and Victoria maintain lists of high priority pest/disease threats which could impact on production, the community or the environment and actively monitor the situation overseas and within Australia and gather information to identify risks)
- developing policy, operational arrangements, and plans (i.e. state or national disease strategies or contingency plans developed to guide the required response activities e.g. PLANTPLAN and AUSVETPLAN and Victorian State Emergency Animal Disease Response Plan)
- ensuring adequate resources, systems and processes are in place
- training response personnel and educating stakeholders and potentially affected industries and communities
- maintaining and developing expertise
- conducting exercises
- evaluating preparedness and response activities
- ensuring the necessary relationships, formal and informal mechanisms are in place across government industry and with Traditional Owners to support biosecurity outcomes.
- ensuring relief and recovery activities are ready to commence concurrently with response activities.

DEECA maintains a 24/7 roster of veterinarians and authorised officers to ensure that all reports of suspected emergency animal diseases are responded to immediately. In addition, duty officers are available seven days a week to respond to emergency plant pest reports.

A State Agency Commander, multiple Regional Agency Commanders and a Resource Officer are on duty every weekend and public holiday to ensure that DEECA can fulfill its biosecurity emergency management responsibilities and quickly initiate an incident management team if required. Availability and standby arrangements are in place so that necessary resources can be accessed.

6.1 Victorian State, Regional and Municipal Planning Arrangements and interoperability

There are several Australian and Victorian Government Ministers responsible for various aspects of biosecurity prevention, response and recovery and they all support the emergency management planning process. In Victoria, under the *Emergency Management Act 2013*, responsibility for preparation of emergency management plans, rests:

- at state level, with the Emergency Management Commissioner
- at regional level, with Regional Emergency Management Planning Committees (REMPCs)
- at municipal level, with Municipal Emergency Management Planning Committees (MEMPCs).

The SEMP outlines the roles of Emergency Management Commissioner, REMPCs and MEMPCs, including function and composition.

Emergency-specific sub-committees at state, regional and municipal levels may provide at-level technical advice and guidance relating to biosecurity emergency management planning.

6.2 Regional Planning

The functions of REMPCs are outlined in the SEMP. DEECA provides representation to REMPCs in accordance with the provisions of the *Emergency Management Act 2013*.

6.3 Municipal Planning

The functions of MEMPCs are outlined in the SEMP. DEECA provides representation to MEMPCs as required.

7. Response

Biosecurity emergencies can vary greatly, in both their scale and complexity, and involve a range of dynamics not seen in a Class 1 natural disaster responses. Operational requirements such as surveillance, tracing, vector management, movement restrictions, treatment, destruction, and disposal require an incident management system which is specific to biosecurity emergencies.

Biosecurity responses rely upon a close interoperability between agencies particularly in incidents involving zoonotic diseases (diseases that transmit from animals to humans) that require close collaboration with the Department of Health (DH); and outbreaks in native wildlife and feral animals that require collaboration with DEECA and some public land managers that have responsibilities for wildlife management and conservation as well as feral animal interventions.

It is important to note that there is a clear differentiation between biosecurity “incidents” and “emergencies”. A biosecurity incident would not trigger a biosecurity emergency response. Biosecurity incidents can be small, localised events that are managed within business as usual (BAU) arrangements as Level 1 events.

7.1 Investigations and alert

When a significant pest or disease is detected, DEECA is required to immediately notify all affected parties (governments and industry bodies) through the Australian Government under the Emergency Animal Disease Response Agreement (EADRA), Emergency Plant Pest Response Deed (EPPRD) or National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement 2.0 (NEBRA).

The Executive Director Biosecurity Victoria, Chief Veterinary Officer, and Chief Plant Health Officer also advise the Emergency Management Commissioner on the identification of imminent significant biosecurity threats.

Biosecurity arrangements apply on a continuing basis and do not need to be activated.

DEECA will immediately commence surveillance activities to delimit the extent of the incident, trace the potential movement pathways of the pest/disease back to the original source of introduction (if possible) and likely movements forward from the detection point, together with implementing quarantine or movement controls to limit further spread.



7.2 Biosecurity responses have distinct characteristics.

Biosecurity responses have distinct characteristics which impacts the management structures and operational approaches (Table 1).

Table 1: Characteristics of a biosecurity emergency response

Facet	Characteristics of a biosecurity emergency response
Complexity	• Different pests or diseases may require completely different approaches to their control. • Policies and control measures, often vary over time, depending on the stage of the response and as developments arise, and may be influenced by scientific, industry and political drivers. • This evolution recognises the need to adapt to the changing situation and, particularly in the case of emerging pests and diseases, the availability of new information.
Movement	• Spread of the disease or pest can be rapid and wide via the movement of hosts (e.g. animals, plants), vectors (e.g. insects, products, vessels), or fomites that passively carry the disease or pest (e.g. clothing, equipment, machinery). Spread can also be by aerosol or in water. • Biosecurity measures typically need to be established very rapidly to limit the spread and may include widescale restrictions on the movement of animals, products, people and vehicles.
Spread	• Rapid dispersal of pests and diseases by natural means (i.e., wind or water-borne spread) or of animal and plant products by road, rail, air and ship can result in a wide affected area, at times including more than one jurisdiction. • Areas and sites affected by the pests and diseases need to be determined by extensive testing and surveillance and may not be easy to determine, especially in the early stages when it is likely that the actual extent of the pest or disease is much greater than what is known at the time. • This can have implications for the impact on industries, the community, tourism and trade, and the resources required to control the disease or pest.
Level of public and industry engagement	• Biosecurity emergencies require early education and information, and continuing engagement with industries, support agencies and the community if they are to succeed. • A unique feature of biosecurity emergencies is that potentially affected industries play a significant role in preparing for and responding to biosecurity incidents. • Industry may be required to part-fund some disease responses, under national cost-sharing arrangements.
Economic and social Impact	• A pest or disease outbreak will affect not only individuals, industry, and the local community, but also, potentially, export trade and the Australian community in general. • The direct impacts on associated industries can also be severe. The most effective way to minimise the impact is through rapid detection of disease or pest and implementation of effective control measures.

Facet	Characteristics of a biosecurity emergency response
	• Impacts are often beyond the immediate area infected and can have significant social, economic, and reputational consequences for producers/industries without disease.
Public health	• Many emergency animal diseases are caused by zoonotic infectious agents — that is, agents that can also infect humans. • Human, pets, livestock, and native animals may be impacted by chemical control measures implemented as part of the response, or directly from the pests under eradication (e.g. invasive ants). • This has important implications for those impacted by the response activities and those working in the response. • In addition, mental health and wellbeing of producers, industry employees and those working in the response operation can be significantly impacted. • It is important that response personnel are aware of appropriate measures to minimise risk to people and ensure appropriate workplace health and safety controls are applied. • Appropriate safety measures need to be part of the public information messaging.
Duration	• Biosecurity emergencies can go for months and in some cases years at a high tempo requiring sustained effort to deliver the response outcomes. • These features influence many aspects of the response including selection of control centre locations (e.g. sports grounds and community halls are not appropriate) and the ability to meet the personnel requirements. • There are also challenges with business continuity for staff removed from their roles for extended periods.
Context	• Victoria works within both established Australian frameworks as well as international standards for biosecurity. • Cost-sharing arrangements for the response are already set for many diseases and are agreed by industry as well as Commonwealth, state and territory jurisdictions.
Scale	• Information on the extent of the pest or disease spread and/or the potential host range is often incomplete. • It is therefore appropriate to commence a wide-scale response (within reason for the pest or disease and its likely impact), and then scale the response as more information becomes available. Resources should be deployed commensurate with need.
Unusual workplace conditions	• Although the chemical, physical and psychological hazards encountered during a pest or disease response are not unique, they are likely to be experienced on an unusual scale and for an extended duration. • This requires that special consideration is given to managing the associated risks.
Biodiversity	• Impacts to wildlife and introduced pest species are likely to be extremely challenging to manage because of the numbers of animals potentially impacted, the fact that many species are highly mobile across the landscape and the difficulty in identifying, treating, and monitoring wild populations. • An effective response will include supporting wildlife rehabilitators in implementing appropriate biosecurity measures for animals within their care.

Facet	Characteristics of a biosecurity emergency response
	• The response may include the management of risk of disease spread by human intervention through interaction with wildlife and introduced pest species.
Aboriginal Cultural Heritage	• Impacts to wild animals that are totemic species will be extremely challenging to manage. • Impacts to plant species that have cultural significance may be extremely challenging to manage. • Potential for control measures to limit access to Country or the practice of traditional land management activities. • Potential for increased obligations for Traditional Owners as land managers where Joint Management Plans may apply.

7.3 Incident Management System

In responding to a biosecurity emergency, DEECA will implement a structure according to the principles of the Australasian Inter-service Incident Management System (AIIMS) and the national Biosecurity Incident Management System (BIMS), with contextual modifications to facilitate the complexity and nuances of biosecurity responses. BIMS is designed to complement state and legislative obligations and sector-specific arrangements described in AUSVETPLAN, AQUAVETPLAN, PLANTPLAN and EMPPLAN (see Figure 6 for two examples of how an Incident Management Team can be structured under BIMS).

The structure of biosecurity incident management will have two functions:

- provision of strategic policy and technical direction; and
- planning and implementation of operational activities.

Under the national Biosecurity Incident Management System (BIMS), five incident levels are recognised to account for escalating complexities and the potential for responses that need coordination of national or international resources (Table 2).

In Victoria, biosecurity emergencies are classified as Level 1, 2 or 3 based on the size, scale and risk of the incident and the resources required to manage it. Level 3 biosecurity emergencies are infrequent, more complex and are classified as major emergencies.

Level 1 Response:

A Level 1 response is a localised response that is managed as a biosecurity incident. In a Level 1 biosecurity response, an Incident Controller will be appointed to control field operations. The Incident Controller could be a Regional/ Senior Manager and will be operating under strategic and technical advice provided by the Chief Technical Officer who has responsibility for the entire response (Table 2). The senior manager will also have responsibility for national or state level coordination under the direction of the Chief Technical Officer and Executive Director Biosecurity Victoria if required.

Level 2 Response:

A Level 2 response is a local or regional response where the size, scale, risk or resource requirements require the establishment of the BIMS structure. A Level 2 response may require activation of the state biosecurity operations centre (SBOC) to support the interface with the national biosecurity emergency arrangements.

The specific characteristics of the locality or area, affected industry sectors, the type of pest or disease and required control measures will determine the appropriate control structures and level of the response. However, in general a Level 2 response may involve multiple sites within a defined geographic area. Control will require a local command centre with potential for forward command posts within or outside the area. It is possible that other forward command posts or local command centres may be established to support incident management, but a small scale and low complexity of each incident may not warrant escalation to level 3 (see 2020 Avian influenza example below).

In some circumstances a Level 2 biosecurity emergency may require the appointment of a State Controller Biosecurity to ensure effective management of the emergency.

A State Controller Biosecurity will be appointed for:

- any Class 2 major biosecurity emergency (regardless of whether this is managed at a level 2 or level 3 arrangement)
- any level 2 or 3 response where Victoria is the lead under national cost-sharing arrangements activated under the EADRA, EPPRD or NEBRA, or
- other circumstances as approved by the Control Agency Officer in Charge.

Where a State Controller Biosecurity is to be appointed, the Agriculture Victoria Chief Executive will brief the Secretary, as the Control Agency Officer in Charge of the biosecurity emergency, recommending the appointment of suitable executives to be appointed as State Controller Biosecurity.

The Emergency Management Commissioner will be consulted as part of the appointment as per the requirements of the State Emergency Management Plan.

In a Level 2 biosecurity emergency, the State Controller Biosecurity will control the response, acting on strategic and technical directions set by the Chief Technical Officer in line with a nationally agreed response plan, when applicable (Figure 5), and reporting to the Executive Director Biosecurity Victoria. The Chief Technical Officer oversees the technical and policy aspects of the response.

A Level 2 event may require activation of the Class 2 cell of the State Control Centre to provide additional coordination support particularly with accessing surge resources. Level 2 responses may require the assistance of resources and specialist support from other jurisdictions, the private sector (e.g. vets) or from other government agencies.

Level 2 responses may also require relief and recovery activities at the local level (see Section 9).

A level 2 response may have national and international implications mostly due to disruptions to export arrangements.

Level 3 Response:

A Level 3 response is a large, complex event across multiple regions or state-wide occurrence of the hazard. A Level 3 response will require significant whole of government coordination owing to the coordination requirements triggering the need for activation of the state control centre and state arrangements.

A Level 3 event will have significant economic impacts and with flow on community impacts and public concern. A Level 3 event will have significant national and international implications.

A Level 3 biosecurity emergency will require the appointment of a State Controller Biosecurity. The Agriculture Victoria Chief Executive will brief the Secretary, as the Control Agency Officer in Charge of a biosecurity emergency, recommending the appointment of suitable executives to be appointed as State Controller Biosecurity.

The Emergency Management Commissioner will be consulted as part of the appointment as per the requirements of the State Emergency Management Plan.

The State Controller Biosecurity will control the response, acting on strategic and technical directions set by the Chief Technical Officer in line with a nationally agreed response plan (Figure 5), and reporting to the Control Agency Officer in Charge.

The separation of the State Controller Biosecurity and Chief Technical Officer roles in Level 3 biosecurity emergencies is required to facilitate differentiation of state-wide operational control and the Chief Technical Officer role in national engagement and provision of technical direction (Figure 5).

A Level 3 event will require activation of the State Control Centre to provide additional whole of government coordination and support.

Victoria has never conducted a level 3 response. Recognising that a level 3 response would be required for a foot-and-mouth disease or similar outbreak, significant planning has been undertaken and detail is provided in the State Emergency Animal Disease Response Plan.

Escalation of a response to a higher level

The Executive Director Biosecurity Victoria is responsible for monitoring the progress, risks and changing circumstances of a response and will advise on whether an emergency should be escalated to a higher level (e.g. from Level 2 to Level 3).

An event specific escalation plan will be developed in the early stages of the event to describe the triggers and considerations for monitoring and escalating a response from level 2 to level 3.

The decision to escalate from Level 2 to Level 3 resides with the Control Agency Officer in Charge and will be made in consultation with the Emergency Management Commissioner.

The factors that will inform escalation are set out in Table 2 and include:

- the spread of the disease/pest from a localised event to multiple regions or state-wide with consideration to the size or complexity of the situation in each locality,
- the level of involvement and coordination needs relating to other departments and agencies in supporting the response, and
- the subsequent increase in impacts and consequences.

Example of a level 2 response: 2020 avian influenza response whereby one local command centre was established and three forward command posts. While there were three different localities (Gannawarra, Gippsland and Meredith), each locality was a relatively small and straightforward response. (Figure 4).

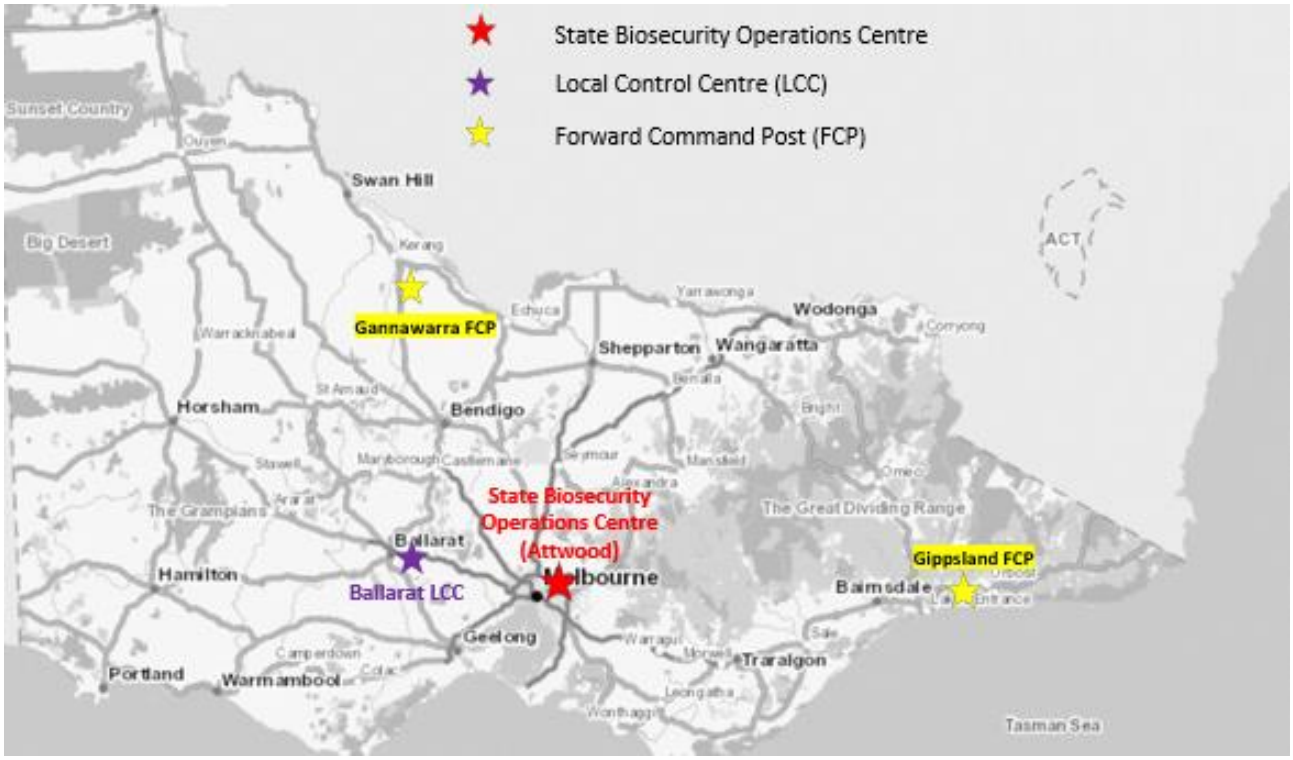


Figure 4: Example of a level 2 response from the 2020 avian influenza response

Table 2: National and Victorian Biosecurity Incident Categories

National BIMS Classification	Victorian Incident Level Classification	Description	Considerations for classification	Impacts and consequences
Level 1 Localised response	**Level 1** Localised response Regional / Senior Manager controls field operations. The CTO sets strategic and technical direction.	Investigation for pest or disease exclusion or very small/limited low complexity incident. Generally managed with local resources under BAU arrangements and would not trigger an emergency response. However, may require regional or state assistance in some circumstances. National response plan may be developed.	A report of a suspected or confirmed biosecurity threat that can be managed with local resources and under BAU arrangements.	Potential for impacts if the threat is confirmed to market access, public health, environmental implications or reputational harm to agency or industry.
Level 2 Local or regional response	**Level 2** Local or regional response IC reports to SCB (f appointed) who reports to the Executive Director Biosecurity. The CTO sets strategic and technical direction for the response.	Confirmation of identification of high-risk biosecurity threat. Establishment of IMT structure, including establishment of the SBOC and one or more LCCs or FCPs. SCB appointed by the CAOiC (DEECA Secretary) to control the response. Deputy SCBs may also be appointed as required. Response may be state-wide, in coordination with national arrangements and other jurisdictions. National response plan likely to be developed. Emergency resourcing arrangements implemented. Partner agencies informed through SEMT, REMTs or local emergency management teams and support may be required. Response may require partner agency staff resourcing support. Response may require resources from other jurisdictions.	The size, scale, risk or resource requirements exceed the capacity to be effectively managed under BAU arrangements with local resources. Resourcing may extend across DEECA, other agencies and includes interjurisdictional arrangements. The complexity of the response is also considered.	The biosecurity threat raises significant public concern. Biosecurity threat poses economic impacts to affected businesses and a threat to life and/or mental well-being in a limited area (locality) or industry. Localised community impacts (e.g. due to restrictions in Control or Restricted areas) Market access issues affect one or more industry sectors in Victoria for the medium to long term.

National BIMS Classification	Victorian Incident Level Classification	Description	Considerations for classification	Impacts and consequences
Level 3 State-wide response **Level 4** Response with resources from other jurisdictions[18] **Level 5** Response with international resources[19]	**Level 3** State-wide response, in coordination with national arrangements and other jurisdictions IC reports to SCB with strategic and technical direction set by CTO under national response plan.	Large and or complex biosecurity response. Multi-jurisdictional impacts requiring national response Establishment of IMT structure, including establishment of SCC, SBOC and one or more LCCs. SCB appointed by the CAOiC (DEECA Secretary). Deputy SCBs may also be appointed as required. National response plan will to be developed. Emergency resourcing arrangements implemented. Partner agencies support required through SCT, SCoT, SEMT and SRRT. Response with resources from other jurisdictions and international resources. Large scale and protracted response requiring early initiation of partner agency staff resourcing support.	A state-wide response being managed at the state level. Response exceeds capacity of DEECA to resource effectively. Significant involvement and coordination needs across government Outbreak or incursion requires national or international resources.	Biosecurity threat and response raise significant public concerns. Biosecurity threat and/or response poses significant economic impacts to businesses and threat to life and/or mental wellbeing across multiple localities (state-wide) or industries. Lengthy international and interstate market access issues for multiple large industry sectors. Significant impacts on Victorian communities Viability of producers in affected sectors is significantly compromised over a long length of time.

Acronyms: BAU = business as usual | **BIMS** = Biosecurity Incident Management System | **CTO** = Chief Technical Officer | **DEECA** = Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action | **IC** = Incident Controller | **IMT** = Incident Management Team | **LCC** = Local Control Centre | **SBOC** = State Biosecurity Operations Centre | **SCB** = State Controller Biosecurity | **SCT** = State Control Team | **SCoT** = State Coordination Team | **SEMT** = State Emergency Management Team | **SRRT** = State Relief and Recovery Team

[18] May apply to Level 2 and Level 3 Victorian Incident Level Classification

[19] May apply to Level 3 Victorian Incident Level Classification

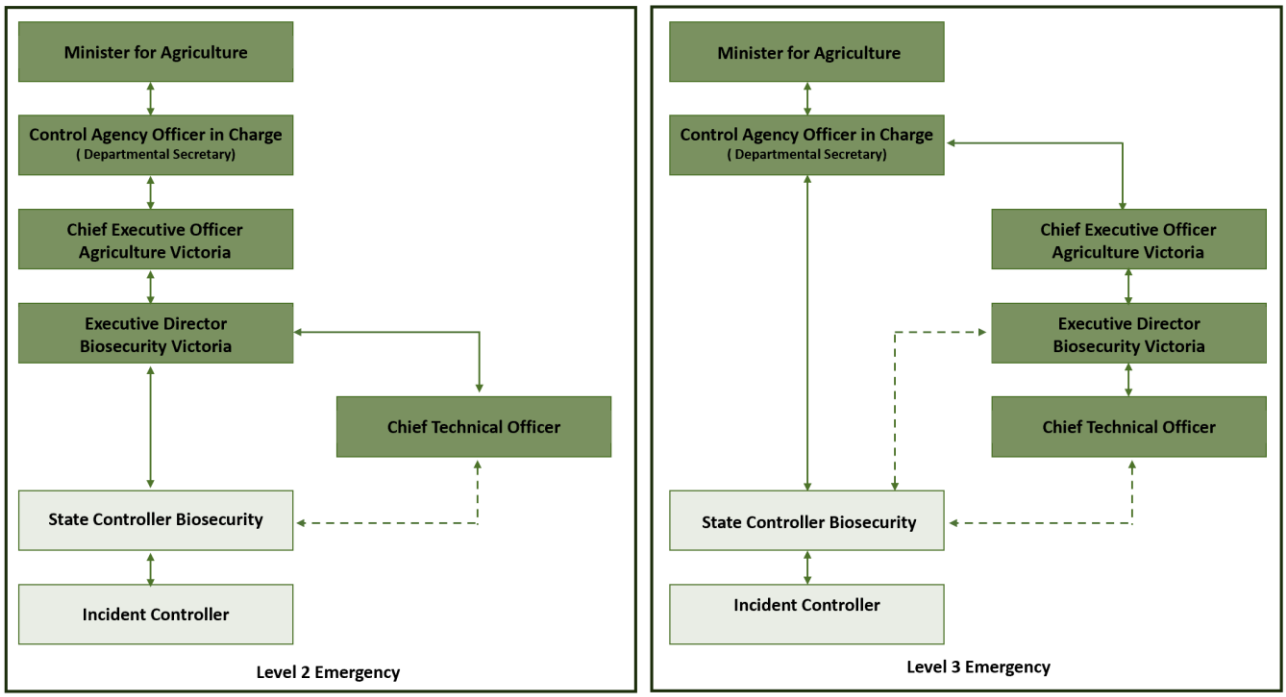


Figure 5: Governance arrangements for Level 2 and Level 3 biosecurity emergency response in Victoria

In some circumstances interstate biosecurity incidents may trigger the need for an emergency response to be established even though the pest or disease is not present in Victoria. In this case the focus of activities will be preventing the spread of the pest or disease to Victoria, completing surveillance to demonstrate freedom of the pest or disease and facilitating safe trade, along with managing relief and recovery activities associated with wider consequences, such as suspension of exports that may impact on Victorian producers and businesses.

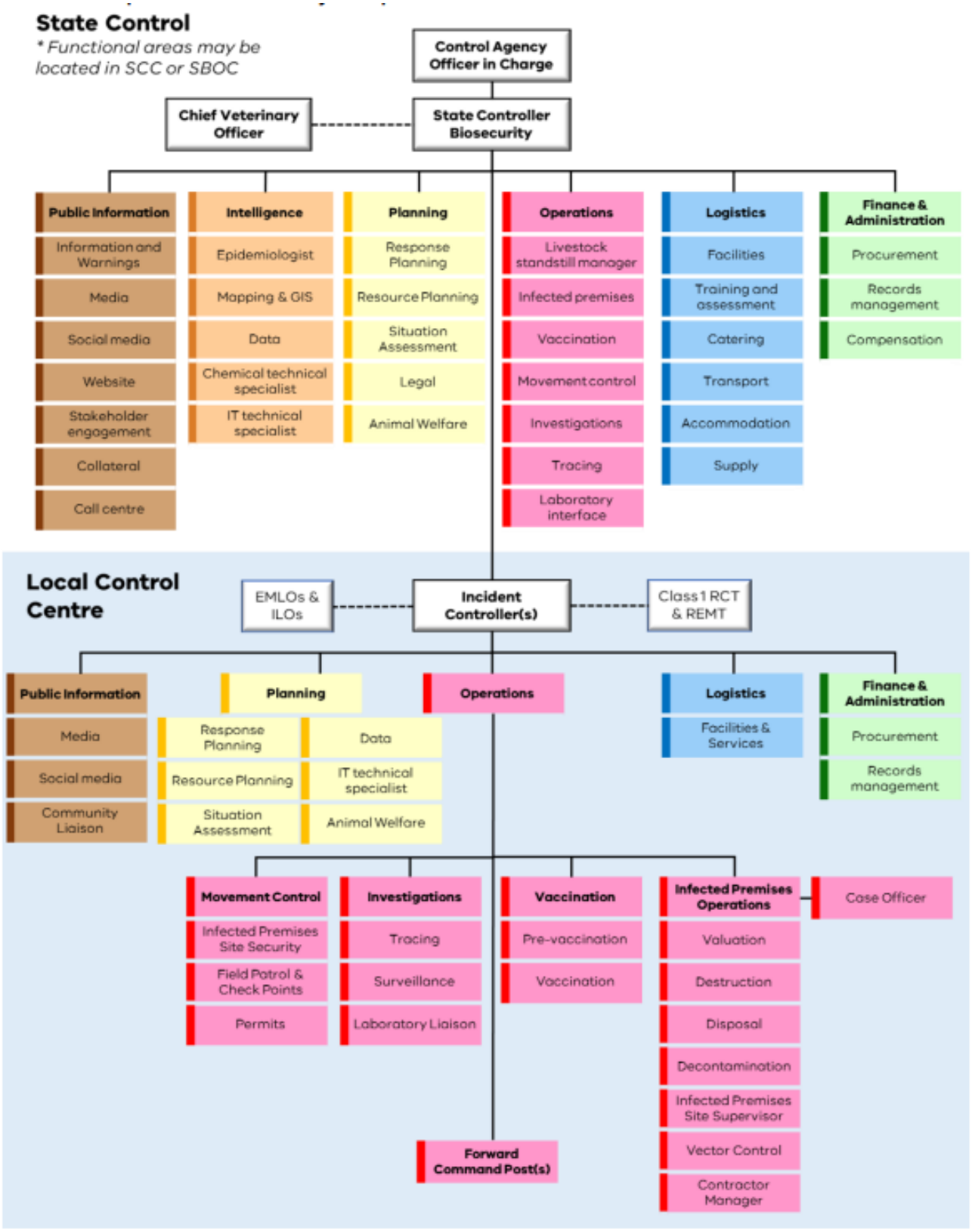


Figure 6: Example of an indicative BIMS Incident Management Team structure at the State and Local Control Centres – Level 3 event. Functional areas may be combined or split further for flexibility and span of control

7.4 Strategic policy and technical direction

Delivery of the response is guided by national and state plans such as the Victorian State Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) Response Plan.

For each biosecurity response, an incident specific Response Plan is developed under the EADRA, EPPRD or NEBRA. These documents provide the high-level strategy and details of the activities to be undertaken, together with an indicative budget. Response Plans must be agreed by all affected parties (governments and industry) through the relevant National Management Group prior to implementation.

The Chief Veterinary Officer or Chief Plant Health Officer leads engagement on behalf of Victoria in national arrangements, is generally the media spokesperson and is responsible for the strategic and technical direction of the response. The Chief Veterinary Officer or Chief Plant Health Officer works very closely with the State Controller Biosecurity and provides technical input, undertakes strategic planning and leads response communications and industry engagement.

Table 3: Nominated Chief Technical Officer for biosecurity hazards

Chief Technical Officer	Hazard	Relevant Consultative Committee[20]
Chief Plant Health Officer	Emergency Plant Pest (including bees)	CCEPP
	Marine pest incursion	CCIMPE
	Vertebrate pest incursion	NBMCC
	Weed and environmental pest incursion	NBMCC
Chief Veterinary Officer	Emergency Animal Disease	CCEAD
	Aquatic Emergency Animal Diseases	AqCCEAD

7.5 Control

During a biosecurity emergency response, DEECA will implement a response control structure and establish operations centres at levels appropriate for the incident. In the case of a biosecurity incident of national significance, the response will require a coordinated approach across multiple government agencies and affected industries. Consequently, response activities will occur and be managed at multiple levels. These may include national, state, local, and field. Where necessary, adjustments may be made to the pre-determined governance structures to facilitate an effective response, for example, adding additional Deputy State Controllers where necessary.

For a biosecurity emergency response, strategic decision-making for the response occurs at the national and state level with state level control and coordination being managed through the **State Biosecurity Operations Centre**. If required, DEECA can request activation of the **State Control Centre** (SCC) managed by Emergency Management Victoria. The **Local Control Centre** and **Forward Command Posts** focus on operational delivery within those parameters.

- **State Control Centre** (SCC): The SCC is Victoria's primary control centre for managing emergencies and would be activated in a Level 3 response. The SCC's responsibility is to ensure the control and coordination strategies and arrangements are appropriate and adequate for current emergencies.
- **State Biosecurity Operations Centre** (SBOC): primary responsibility for the strategic planning and coordination of biosecurity operational activities across Victoria.
- **Local Control Centre** (LCC): primary responsibility for planning, conducting, and supporting all operational activities in its geographical area of responsibility.
- **Forward Command Post** (FCP): There may be a need to establish one or more FCPs. The FCPs will manage field activities within a defined geographic area, with a focus on an identified task or range of

[20] Representative may be different from the Chief Technical Officer (see Figure 2)

tasks. FCPs are usually established to manage field activities associated with several premises or well-defined area, manage specific operational tasks in a defined area or conduct operational activities in a remote area.

A Regional Control approach is rarely established for biosecurity responses, however regional emergency management structures and arrangements may be important for supporting operational activities and for coordinating activities between agencies.

7.5.1 Zoonotic risk management in a biosecurity response

Some biosecurity emergencies involve zoonotic diseases which can have an impact on human health. Incidents involving zoonotic diseases will be reported to DH which is responsible for undertaking the assessment of human health risks and responding to human health issues.

All human health issues will be led by DH in accordance with the State Health Emergencies Sub-Plan.

In responding to incidents affecting both human and animal health, the appropriate governance is determined by the Chief Veterinary Officer, Chief Health Officer or delegates, and may include the formation of:

- a joint IMT, or
- concurrent animal health and human health IMTs with liaison officers appointed to enable a coordinated response.

The response to outbreaks, incidents and emergencies affecting human and animal health will be delivered in keeping with:

- the Memorandum of Understanding between DEECA and DH for the Joint Management of Zoonotic Diseases and Related Human and Veterinary Public Health Matters, and
- the subordinate Zoonotic diseases joint protocol between the Department of Health and Agriculture Victoria.

7.6 Planning

Planning manages the collection, collation, analysis, interpretation, and dissemination of information, and in biosecurity responses is delivered at the strategic and operational levels. The planning function acts as an information centre and through providing information contributes to the situational awareness of all staff involved in the response.

Epidemiology is a critical function within planning in biosecurity emergencies. It informs planning on the evolution of a disease outbreak or pest incursion and the appropriate management interventions.

Biosecurity responses generate very large amounts of data which requires analysis to provide information to inform decision making. Therefore, planning will include a large technical analyses and data management sub-function. The exercise of legislated powers with respect to movement controls, activities on properties and potential payment of compensation require a significant legal function to be included within the planning function.

The planning unit also forecasts future needs and acquires human resources from across DEECA, the Emergency Service Organisations through Emergency Management Victoria and other departmental agencies.

7.7 Operations

Operational activities in a biosecurity response can be very significant encompassing multiple regions and several different activities. The main activities are:

- **Investigation** – gathering information that will assist in identifying the source and potential spread of the pest or
  - **Tracing** - to identify where pests or disease may have moved from or to.
  - **Surveillance** – initially this is focused on undertaking surveillance within a region or across the state to identify any affected sites that have not been detected through investigations.
    - **Proof of Freedom -** the later stages of the response may become focused on gathering evidence to demonstrate the successful eradication in order to reinstate a disease or pest-free status for Victoria and regain market access.
- **Movement Controls** – Depending on the situation and level of risk, a Control Area, Restricted Area, or Infected Premises may be declared (see Figure 7). These declarations will specify any prohibitions, restrictions and requirements which are required to operate in the declared area. A national livestock standstill is the highest level of movement control, where the movement of all susceptible species is prohibited for a minimum of 72 hours.
- **Suspected and Infected site operations** – Typically including quarantine, valuation, destruction, waste disposal, decontamination, and monitoring. In the first instance, advice on waste disposal strategies may be sought internally from DEECA (Climate Action and Circular Economy Division- Waste Emergencies Unit). Specialist advice on disposal options may be sought from the Environment Protection Authority Victoria (EPA), landfill operators and local councils (as appropriate) as disposal on site (on property) may not be an option. Approvals from EPA may be required for both onsite disposal and offsite transport and disposal of wastes. During a major biosecurity event where significant volumes of waste requires offsite disposal to either existing waste infrastructure or event specific disposal locations, a separate cell may be required to be established in the operations area to coordinate the logistics associated with offsite waste transport and disposal.
- **Relief** – Considerations for the welfare of animals is an important priority when enacting quarantine, movement controls and other biosecurity measures. Relief services may also be provided to primary producers and rural landholders impacted by biosecurity emergencies as well as impacted industry employees (note: if the only relief services are compensation and animal welfare, these would not be services coordinated by regional relief coordinators (responsible for multi-agency coordination) as both are the responsibility of DEECA (Agriculture Victoria).
- **Wild and feral pest populations** – Movement controls, exclusion, monitoring, and other operational activities for wild and feral pest populations may be different to those applicable for livestock. Setting up operational activities for these wild populations will also require an understanding of the ecological impacts of a species being impacted.

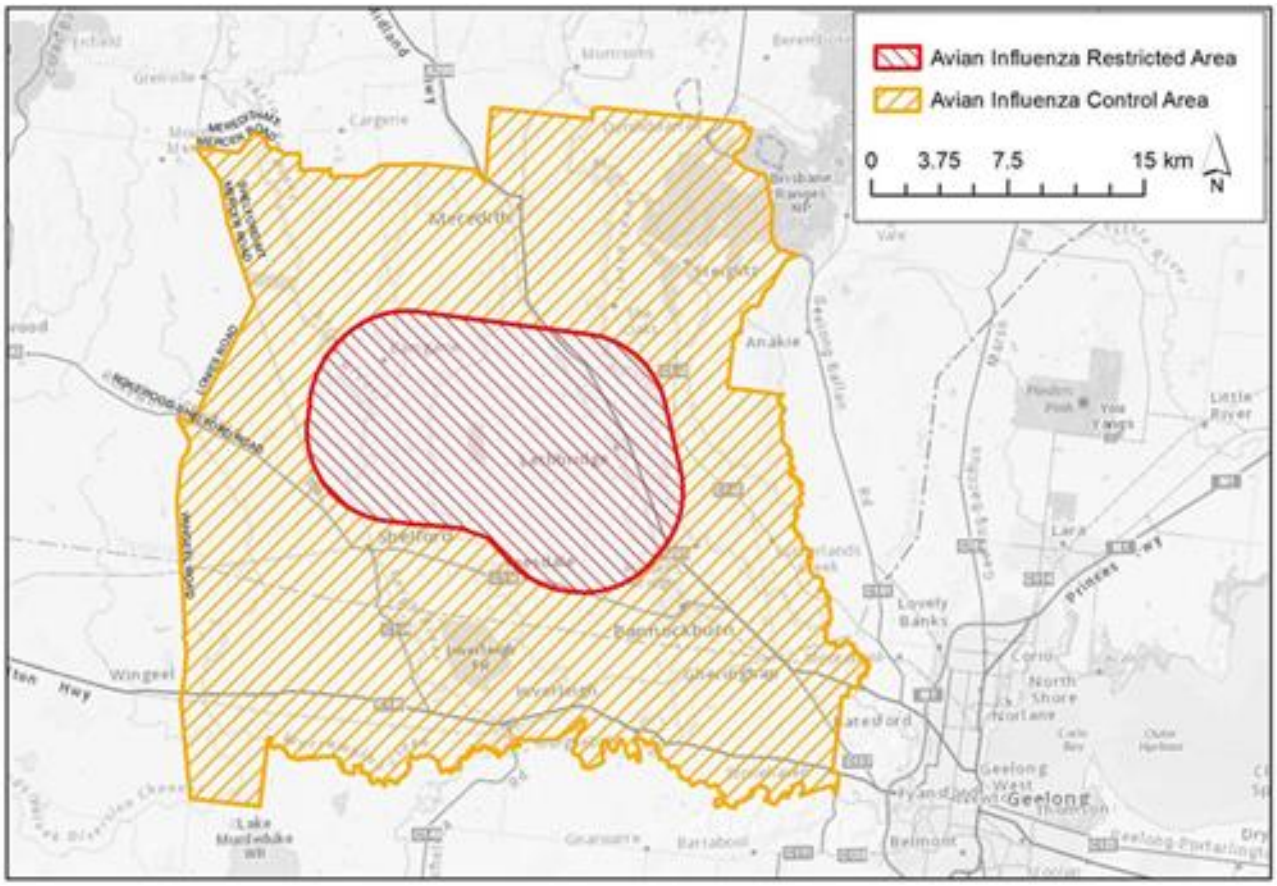


Figure 7: An example of declared areas during the 2020 Avian Influenza outbreak.

7.8 Logistics

The logistics function delivered in a biosecurity emergency response is consistent with that implemented for other emergencies. It is responsible for the provision of contracted resources including human and physical resources, facilities, services, and materials required by the other functions in the response. The delivery of this function may differ from other sectors primarily in the requirement to acquire specific biosecurity or animal/plant health skills in the response staff and the specialist equipment they may require.

7.9 Finance and administration

A significant component of the operational activities, especially those on site, may be undertaken by the private sector. Therefore, a finance and administration function is often established separate to logistics, to ensure that the capability and capacity required is procured and the financial aspects managed effectively. The area is also responsible for ensuring document management and record keeping for the emergency.

7.10 Public information

Public information is time-critical information that audiences need to respond appropriately during and after a biosecurity incident. Information is disseminated to, and received from, the public/communities, affected industries, the media, stakeholders and within an agency/organisation.

Timely, accurate, consistent, and tailored information helps the community and affected stakeholders prevent the spread of pests, diseases and invasive species and aid containment, control and eradication efforts.

Public information also plays an important role in informing media and the public about invoked laws, such as movement restrictions and controlled quarantine areas.

Effective communication and engagement are vital in responding to an incident. In addition to assisting with the response, keeping the public informed improves the perceived effectiveness of a response and can assist with recovery.

In biosecurity emergencies, the early education and continuing engagement with industries, border animal care and welfare sector, support agencies and the community are crucial. A successful response relies on wide-scale voluntary compliance with restrictions, public reporting of suspected cases or breaches of movement controls and maintaining public and industry trust and confidence over an extended duration when they may be experiencing very difficult circumstances owing to the impacts of the pests or disease or the measures to control it.

The public information section will adapt communications and engagement techniques and channels as the situation needs, which can include but is not limited to: paid advertising, community and stakeholder engagement such as events and webinars, VicEmergency, outbound calls and SMS and leveraging other channels appropriate to the incident and the audience.

The National Biosecurity Communication and Engagement Network (NBCEN) is the national group tasked with producing and disseminating nationally consistent public information in response to animal, plant, and other biosecurity incidents. Regardless of incident level, the NBCEN can be used to coordinate the public information response nationally. The NBCEN will circulate media releases, talking points and other public information material across jurisdictions to ensure consistent messaging.

During a biosecurity incident the NBCEN:

- develops National Talking Points and facilitates the consultation process of those messages
- reports to and provides strategic communication advice to the relevant technical consultative committee or National Management Group
- develops a national communication and engagement strategy for agreement by the relevant technical consultative committee or National Management Group and oversees its implementation where required
- ensures that national media and communication procedures for biosecurity incidents are activated and implemented accordingly
- explains policies, plans and practices to all stakeholders clearly, consistently, openly and quickly
- facilitates the flow of information between jurisdictions (related to public information activities)
- provides experienced public information officers to other jurisdictions (where available and/or necessary)
- ensures the key principles of crisis communication are upheld throughout a response to a biosecurity incident.

The national Biosecurity Incident Public Information Manual also provides valuable templates and guidance for use in a biosecurity incident.

For major emergency animal disease responses, a whole of Victorian Government Communications plan is in place.

Emergency Management Joint Public Information Committee (EMJPIC) meets for those incidents where coordination of messaging across the Victorian Government is required. The overarching responsibilities of EMJPIC include:

1. Provide assurance to the Emergency Management Commissioner, State Control Team and State Emergency Management Team that Whole of Government communications planning, strategy and delivery before, during and after major emergencies, are in place.
2. Develop and implement media, communication and engagement planning where:
    a. An emergency requires a multiple-agency response, or
    b. the portfolio responsibility is shared by multiple Ministers, or
    c. an incident has the potential for significant consequences for communities.
3. Strengthening Whole of Victorian Government communications as well as state, region and incident communications and community engagement before, during and after major emergencies.
4. Discuss and determine media, communication and community engagement functions and responsibilities before, during, and after emergencies for all communities including Culturally and Linguistically Diverse (CALD) communities and people with a disability.

7.11 Emergency information and warnings

Issuing of community information is a key incident priority. This encompasses community warnings detailing incident information that are timely, relevant, and tailored to assist community members make informed decisions.

Following the detection of a biosecurity outbreak, DEECA will work quickly to publish key information online. This may be on the Agriculture Victoria website for most incidents, and for Level 3 incidents of concern, a standalone website may be activated through the Victorian Government's Single Digital Presence. This online information will include the following messages:

- a description of the pest or disease
- symptoms of the disease and how to report suspected detections
- details about the outbreak
- what government is doing
- what the government requires the community to do
- what can be done to reduce the risk (biosecurity measures)
- what are the rules / legal obligations (e.g. movement controls)

DEECA will also work with the Warnings and Advice Duty Officer at the State Control Centre to provide community information, advice, or warnings as appropriate. In extreme threat circumstances (such as an outbreak of foot-and-mouth disease), the Class 2 State Controller Biosecurity may determine that public warnings are required. These warnings will be issued by the Warnings and Advice Duty Officer. DEECA will liaise with local agencies as appropriate to ensure affected communities are receiving timely and relevant advice. The public will be asked (and are required under legislation) to report suspicion of a pest or disease.

DEECA will also use its social media and industry networks to disseminate information.

DAFF will also publish relevant information on the federal Outbreak website with information based on National Talking Points: outbreak.gov.au

The DEECA Customer Contact Centre (**136 186**) will be used to manage incoming enquiries for Level 1 incidents. For a Level 2 and 3 outbreaks, Agriculture Victoria may consider activating the VicEmergency Hotline through the Memorandum of Understanding between the State of Victoria through DEECA and Agriculture Victoria. Other hotlines may be used as required, such as the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888 and the Exotic Plant Pest Hotline on 1800 884 881.

The Chief Technical Officer may determine that public warnings are required. These warnings will be issued following the Joint Standard Operating Procedure (JSOP) 4.02 and Victorian Warning Arrangements.

Where warnings are required, the State Control Centre will issue them on behalf of DEECA. These will be available at: www.emergency.vic.gov.au

Consideration will also be given to multicultural communities and local needs – including provision of information through diverse languages and communication channels.

In the event of a Level 3 emergency animal disease, the Whole of Victorian Government Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) Communications Plan will be activated in collaboration with the State Control Centre.

7.12 Liaison

The Liaison function is a key part of the biosecurity response and acts as the point of contact for communication and coordination between the Incident Management function and industry, other departments and agencies, as well as organisations including wildlife welfare stakeholders and groups. There are different types of liaison functions which include:

Industry liaison: The cost sharing arrangements under the response agreements mean that industries have a say in emergency response decisions. There is a clear expectation that affected industries will be engaged closely at all levels of the response. There are designated roles for Industry Liaison Officers within the response structure, provided by the affected industries, to support those responses occurring under national arrangements. In accordance with BIMS, these roles may be referred to as Liaison Livestock Industry or Liaison Plant Industry Depending on the size and number of sectors impacted, an Industry Liaison Coordinator may be appointed.

The liaison officers will report to the State Controller Biosecurity. In a complex event where, multiple industries are impacted and multiple liaison officers are established, an Industry Liaison Coordinator may be appointed to facilitate the industry liaison function and would report to the State Controller Biosecurity.

Traditional Owner and/or Traditional Owner Corporations liaison: Given that a response to a biosecurity emergency may have significant state-wide implication that impact Aboriginal Cultural Hertiage and Traditional Owner groups' cultural rights, practices, and relationship to Country, DEECA will work to ensure engagement and partnership with Traditional Owner groups occurs through regional or emergency management mechanisms that are in place during a biosecurity emergency. In addition, a liaison officer role may be appointed to operate at a state-wide level to ensure that there is a key point of contact to coordinate and partner with those Traditional Owner groups that are impacted by a biosecurity response. An officer may similarly also be appointed at an incident management level to identify cultural heritage considerations, and also liaise with impacted Traditional Owner groups[21]. Importantly, these liaison officers will not represent or make decisions for Traditional Owner groups.

7.13 Coordination

The response may require operational engagement with other parts of state and local governments and agencies.

Emergency Management Liaison Officers (EMLOs) will be put in place to support effective interoperability, coordination of resources, and the achievement of the State Emergency Management Priorities as required. The requirement for EMLOs will vary depending on the nature and scale of the incident which may for example, require a coordinated approach to manage the safety of emergency services personnel, safety of community members, including vulnerable community members or tourists, the protection of livelihoods and economic production, or the protection of cultural, biodiversity and social values of the environment.

As the Control Agency, DEECA will liaise with other departments and agencies in accordance with their responsibilities outlined in the SEMP and consider adjusting the governance structure as required.

For significant responses the State Controller Biosecurity will liaise with EMV through the Emergency Management Commissioner to identify current and emerging risks, or threats regarding the emergency, and implement proactive response strategies.

[21] Depending on the event, this support may be delivered via the Agriculture Victoria or DEECA regional directors.

7.14 Stand down

A biosecurity response can enter the stand down phase following one of the following determinations:

- The successful eradication of the pest or disease.
- The determination that a pest or disease cannot be eradicated, but it can be contained within a defined area.
- The determination that a pest or disease cannot be eradicated, and no further emergency actions are to be implemented.

Should a pest or disease eradication be determined not to be feasible, there may be a Transition to Management Phase implemented. In this phase, specified activities will be undertaken to facilitate the smooth transition from an emergency response to ongoing industry management.

7.15 Transfer of control

A detailed description of transfer of control arrangements is provided in the SEMP.

7.16 Relief function

Whilst Victorian arrangements incorporate relief into response structures, national biosecurity arrangements and the nature of biosecurity incidents means relief and recovery activities commence at the onset of the response and occur concurrently with response activities.

The consequences and therefore the required relief and recovery activities are highly interdependent on the decisions and actions taken as part of responding to the biosecurity emergency. This is further described in Section 9: Relief and recovery.

8 Consequence management

The consequences of a biosecurity emergency can vary greatly depending on factors such as: the pest or disease involved, the type of industry, natural or human environment affected, and the extent to which the pest or disease have consequences for producers and access to national and international markets. Outbreaks in other jurisdictions can also have significant consequences to Victorian producers and other businesses, even though the pest or disease is not present in Victoria.

Biosecurity emergencies may have significant consequences for the economy, domestic and international markets, the natural environment, cultural heritage, as well as social impacts to individuals, community, and amenity.

Where response operations require the destruction of plants or animals, imposition of movement restrictions that limit trade, or treatments that reduce the value of the product, there will be flow-on impacts to businesses and the broader community.

There can be loss or trauma in the community because of:

- The destruction of stock or crops and a farming enterprise that may have been built up over an extended time with immediate loss of livelihood and sense of purpose.
- Personal trauma from the destruction of gardens and street plantings or from suffering, death or destruction of pets, livestock, and wildlife.
- Changes in the community perceptions of those that have been affected by the pest or disease – for example being ostracised by the community or blamed for bringing the pest or disease to the area.
- Impacts to First Nations Peoples ‘connection to land and Country, cultural heritage values and aspirations for self-determination.
- Impacts to human health, including mental health and wellbeing.

- Impacts on conservation and wildlife welfare and care groups who may feel helpless if there are no viable interventions to mitigate deaths of wildlife.
- Impacts on native flora fauna, and habitats and loss of access to public land from response activities.
- Disruption to cross-border communities in conducting daily business or accessing services.
- Social impacts to individuals, households, and communities.
- Impacts to groups who may be disproportionally affected by biosecurity risks due to their transient nature, limited access to resources or specific community practices.
- Impacts to individuals from relocation due to direct or indirect business impacts e.g. businesses closing.

Businesses and individuals that operate in the affected industry, or are dependent on it, may be directly or indirectly affected with loss of income or impacted by the restrictions or loss of domestic or international market access.

The consequences of many small biosecurity incidents that meet the definition of 'emergency' are managed through normal or business continuity arrangements of industry, agencies, or government. These are defined as non-major emergencies in the SEMP.

Under the *Emergency Management Act (2013)*, the Emergency Management Commissioner is responsible for the coordination of agencies who are managing consequences of major emergencies, including biosecurity emergencies. The Emergency Management Commissioner fulfills this function through the State Consequence Coordinator.

The State Consequences Coordinator will provide systems-level consequence management coordination, with agencies remaining responsible for the management of consequences specific to their respective portfolios as per the SEMP.

Joint planning will be required in circumstances where concurrent emergencies in and around impact areas could significantly affect the community and potentially an agency's ability to respond.

Owners and operators of critical infrastructure providers maintain the continuity of services and minimise the adverse consequences to the community of service interruptions and impacts to infrastructure. In an emergency, relevant lead and support agencies and government departments are responsible for managing the consequences of existing or possible impacts on the specific infrastructure or service that they are responsible for managing or regulating under relevant legislation. Control and lead agencies, as well as critical infrastructure providers must also communicate how they are doing this to communities, stakeholders, and government.

9 Relief and recovery

Owing to the potential risks associated with trade and market access, as well as the potentially lengthy (months to years) duration of biosecurity responses undertaken in Australia, planning for recovery should commence during the response phase. Relief and recovery activities may need to be stood up and delivered concurrently with response activities for Level 2 and Level 3 events. For this reason, relief and recovery planning and activities are initially considered together, noting relief services may not always be needed.

In some circumstances (e. g., foot-and-mouth disease incursions), interstate biosecurity incidents may trigger the need for relief and recovery services to Victorian producers even though the disease is not physically present in Victoria.

The nature and extent of relief and recovery support required for a biosecurity event will depend on the size, scale and complexity of the event and emerging economic and social impacts that arise over potentially long response and recovery phases.

Planning for and delivery of relief and recovery in a biosecurity event is a shared responsibility that requires collaboration and coordination between individuals, communities, Traditional Owners and/ or Traditional Owner Corporations, non-government organisations, businesses, all levels of government (local, state, and federal) and other partners. In addition, providing relief and recovery assistance to Traditional Owner groups including Aboriginal communities affected by a biosecurity incident requires adherence to culturally competent and sensitive approaches.

The SEMP sets out relief and recovery responsibilities for government departments and agencies in relation to emergency management. Agencies with relief and recovery responsibilities prepare and maintain a range of relevant plans, strategies and frameworks, ensuring that these align with National Principles for Disaster Recovery.

In most circumstances, relief and recovery will be delivered at the local level aligned with the localised response activities, subject to funding. DEECA will coordinate relief and recovery activities in collaboration with the relevant local councils and other relevant agencies. This may be facilitated through emergency management teams being established at local or regional levels as appropriate.

In some Level 3 events (such as foot-and-mouth disease), regional and/or state arrangements may be established as per the State EAD response plan.

Impact assessment and consequence mapping will be undertaken in the early stages of a response to identify relief and recovery needs unique to each biosecurity emergency. Information from these assessments will be used to develop a relief and/or recovery plan, as required, to appropriately support individuals, industries and communities for a given biosecurity emergency. DEECA will work with other relevant departments and agencies to plan for and deliver relief and recovery activities associated with the biosecurity emergency.

Relief and recovery support may be provided to support individuals, businesses, and communities, in addition to the valuation and compensation scheme (see Section 9.1) which aims to offset losses from the destruction of stock and property as part of biosecurity control measures. Relief and recovery are not covered under national cost sharing arrangements for a biosecurity emergency, such as the EADRA. Funding arrangements for relief and recovery will be determined by the Victorian Government in accordance with the scale and complexity of the emergency.

Relief and recovery activities may include:

- Payment of compensation or reimbursement of costs for destroyed stock, crops and or property subject to conditions (see section 9.1).
- The provision of information, including how to access available relief and recovery services for affected industries and communities including tailored support for CALD communities as needed.
- Provision of rural counselling services to support affected producers to access financial and other relevant services.

- Other support mechanisms for impacted industry and communities, potentially including:
  - Support to affected communities and businesses including psychological and psychosocial support to address mental health and wellbeing issues.
  - Coordination of measures to support re-establishment of trade.

9.1 Compensation and/or owner reimbursement costs – Valuation and compensation schemes

To support the effective control and eradication of diseases and pests, financial compensation or owner reimbursement costs may be payable to producers for livestock, crops, product, and property that is destroyed for the purpose of controlling, eradicating, or preventing the spread of certain exotic diseases or pests.

All industry and government parties who are a signatory to the national emergency response deeds contribute to funding the costs of responding to an emergency plant pest or animal disease, which includes compensation arrangements or owner reimbursement costs.

Compensation (EADRA) and/or owner reimbursement costs (EPPRD) are shared under the relevant deed and may be paid to those owners who are directly impacted by the biosecurity response (i.e. those whose loss was incurred for the purpose of eradicating the emergency pest or disease). It is important to note that this is limited to industries who are signatories to the EADRA and EPPRD.

Payments are not available for consequential or production losses.

In Victoria financial compensation is paid under the *Livestock Disease Control Act 1994*.

For example, the *Livestock Disease Control Act 1994* governs the valuation and compensation arrangements for compensable exotic diseases, to the owner for any domestic livestock, premises, livestock products, fodder, fittings, or vehicles destroyed under the Act for the purpose of controlling, eradicating or preventing the spread of an exotic disease; and livestock that is certified by an inspector as having died of the disease.

Compensation under the *Livestock Disease Control Act 1994* is irrespective of national cost-sharing arrangements. Victoria is expected to appropriately respond to biosecurity emergencies regardless of the availability of national cost-sharing funding. However, under the EADRA and EPPRD, eligible compensation/owner reimbursement costs may be recouped by the Victorian government under the cost-sharing arrangements.

10 Capability

10.1 Human resources

DEECA will, in the first instance, utilise its own human resources or those directly within its control (through a pre-existing resourcing arrangement) prior to requesting support from other agencies.

There are a range of options available to DEECA when requesting external resources, including:

- Emergency Response Coordinator at the appropriate tier (municipal or regional)
- Emergency Management Commissioner (if seeking state-wide or federal resources)
- National Emergency Management Agency via the Emergency Management Commissioner (if seeking generic federal, inter-state or international resources, including Australian Defence Force)
- Interstate Deployment Arrangements for Biosecurity Responses (if seeking interstate biosecurity personnel, including the National Biosecurity Response Team)
- DAFF may provide staff or coordinate international biosecurity personnel through the International Animal Health Emergency Reserve.

Surge workforce resources may be derived from the broader Victorian Public Service (VPS) and emergency services organisations. VPS surge workforce resources will be requested and coordinated by DEECA

through resource sharing arrangements. Modelling for a large-scale EAD such as foot-and-mouth disease indicates that a large workforce of approximately 5,000 personnel would be required to manage a large-scale event for the first 12 weeks. Additional information for the resourcing and management of an EAD surge workforce is set out in the State Emergency Animal Disease (EAD) Response Plan.

10.2 Assistance from interstate

The National Biosecurity Response Team (NBRT) comprises government personnel from around Australia, with skills and expertise in the planning and practical implementation of biosecurity emergency responses.

NBRT members are equipped to fill key management positions in control centres during a response. They can be deployed as individuals, small teams, or a large team in the event of a biosecurity emergency response in one or more states.

During a response, NBRT members and other State/Territory resources with the required capabilities are deployed through the Interstate Deployment Arrangements for Biosecurity Responses.

10.3 Mutual aid arrangements

Victoria has a Memoranda of Understanding in place with South Australia and New South Wales to enhance collaboration for biosecurity emergencies that occur near the border. Collaboration activities include resource sharing, co-location and management of control centres and development of consistent policies.

An agreement is also in place with the Australian Veterinary Association to support DEECA with veterinary expertise in emergencies.

These mutual aid arrangements apply only to the initial response to the emergency and do not require approval prior to activation.

10.4 Assistance from overseas

The National Emergency Management Agency, in conjunction with the Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, is responsible for coordinating information on offers of physical assistance from overseas countries.

In addition to these general arrangements, there are specific international support arrangements managed by DAFF to facilitate access to veterinarians and other specialist animal health personnel from New Zealand, Canada, the United States of America, Ireland and the United Kingdom. Requests for assistance will be coordinated through the DAFF, in consultation with the National Emergency Management Agency.

Prior to deployment and/or receipt of international or Australian Government resources the State Controller Biosecurity will consult with the Emergency Management Commissioner.

10.5 Assistance from industry and the community

DEECA works with a number of industry sectors to develop specialist capabilities that can be mobilised in the event of biosecurity emergencies.

For example, in the apiary sector the State Quarantine Response Team consists of private and professional apiarists who are trained to work alongside DEECA staff in conducting surveillance and treatment for emergency pests and diseases of honeybees.

Veterinary expertise is often one of the limiting resources during large scale animal health emergencies. DEECA works with other jurisdictions and the Australian Veterinary Association (AVA) to maintain arrangements for engaging private veterinary practitioners to assist in an outbreak response. Private veterinarians will be engaged either by service level agreements or casual employment arrangements.

Other specialised experts and services from industry and the private sector may be engaged through contracts, supplier panel arrangements, as casuals or through labour hire to support specific activities.

10.6 Support agencies

A range of government and non-government agencies/organisations have the skills, expertise, and/or resources to support biosecurity emergency response, relief and recovery.

These agencies include:

- Aboriginal Cultural Heritage: First Peoples State Relations
- Ambulance Victoria
- Australian Veterinary Association Primesafe
- Bureau of Meteorology
- Civil Aviation Safety Authority
- Country Fire Authority
- Dairy Food Safety Victoria
- Department of Education and Training
- Department of Families, Fairness and Housing
- Department of Government Services
- Department of Health
- Department of Jobs, Skills, Industry and Regions
- Department of Transport and Planning
- Emergency Management Victoria
- Emergency Recovery Victoria
- Environment Protection Authority
- Game Management Authority
- Municipal Councils
- Parks Victoria
- Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals
- Veterinary Practitioners Registration Board of Victoria
- Victoria Police
- Victoria State Emergency Service
- Victorian Cross Border Commissioner
- Victorian Farmers Federation
- Victorian Fisheries Authority

Refer to the SEMP for further details of the roles and responsibilities support agencies may undertake during a biosecurity emergency response.

10.7 Shared responsibility

The SEMP recognises that building safer and more resilient communities is the shared responsibility of all Victorians, not just the emergency management sector. Everyone has some role to play to plan and prepare for, prevent, respond to and support recovery from emergencies. Further information about shared responsibility is outlined in the SEMP.

10.8 Concurrent emergencies

Given the potentially prolonged duration of a major biosecurity emergency, a response is likely to occur concurrently with other major emergencies. When concurrent emergencies arise, they may require consideration of how control measures, resources and other operations are deployed to address different priorities in accordance with the State Emergency Management Priorities.

There may be some cases where resources from other jurisdictions may need to be considered to control a concurrent emergency that is threatening life and provide relief from suffering.

Reallocating resources from a biosecurity response may result in significant uncontrolled spread of the pest or disease, as well as the increase in consequences and impacts on industry and community owing to the nature of the risk.

The State Controller Biosecurity must consult with the Emergency Management Commissioner, the State Response Controller, and other relevant Class 2 State Controllers to determine and document appropriate control and coordination arrangements in a concurrent emergency.

Whenever there are concurrent major emergencies and competing demands for resources, the Emergency Management Commissioner will work with appointed state and regional controllers of relevant Class 1 and Class 2 events to ensure that state emergency management priorities are met, including examining whether other resources can be accessed.

10.9 Interoperability

Interoperability provides a mechanism for achieving better outcomes by allowing Control and Support agencies to effectively work together before, during and after an incident. It also provides a foundation for meaningful connections with the community and a wide range of partner agencies.

To achieve a cooperative response to emergencies, each agency maintains an understanding of the systems, structures, resources, capabilities and statutory obligations of the other agencies, and there are multiple inter-agency agreements to allow operations across footprints and define how agencies interact in those circumstances. Interoperability maximises the capability of the agencies to work effectively and efficiently together to deliver seamless information, communications, and technology.

Emergency management agencies also work collaboratively with a wide range of industry bodies, community groups, Traditional Owners, and other stakeholders regarding risk related issues. This includes collaboration with Victorian, interstate, and international emergency management agencies in order to share knowledge, improve emergency management policy and practice, and to optimise use of resources.

11 Review and evaluation

In accordance with the provisions of the *Emergency Management Act 2013*, this Plan will be reviewed every three years, or more frequently as appropriate. This Plan will be exercised within this three-year planning cycle. DEECA as the Control Agency will organise an operational debrief with participating agencies after cessation of a Level 2 or 3 biosecurity emergency response in accordance with EMV guidelines. All agencies, including recovery agencies, will be represented with a view to evaluating the effectiveness of the response and to recommend any changes to improve future biosecurity emergency responses.



12 Appendices

Appendix 12.1: Acts relevant to biosecurity in Victoria

Title	Commonwealth or State legislation
Aboriginal Heritage Act 2006	State
Agricultural and Veterinary Chemicals (Control of Use) Act 1992	State
Agricultural and Veterinary Chemicals (Control of Use) Regulations 2017	State
Agricultural and Veterinary Chemicals (Control of Use) (Ruminant Feed) Regulations 2015	State
Biological Control Act 1986	State
Biosecurity Act 2015	Commonwealth
Biosecurity Regulations 2016	Commonwealth
Catchment and Land Protection Act 1994	State
Catchment and Land Protection Regulations 2012	State
Conservation, Forests and Lands Act 1987	State
Crown Land (Reserves) Act 1978	State
Dairy Act 2000	State
Drugs, Poisons and Controlled Substances Act 1981	State
Emergency Management Act 1986 and 2013	State
Environment Protection Act 2017	State
Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999	Commonwealth
Firearms Act 1996	State
Food Act 1984	State
Fisheries Act 1995	State
Flora and Fauna Guarantee Act 1988	State
Impounding of Livestock Act 1994	State
Livestock Disease Control Act 1994	State
Livestock Disease Control Regulations 2017	State
Livestock Management Act 2010	State
Marine and Coastal Act 2018	State
Marine Safety Act 2010	State
Meat Industry Act 1993	State
Native Title Act 1993	Commonwealth
National Parks Act	State
Planning and Environment Act 1987	State
Plant Biosecurity Act 2010	State

Plant Biosecurity Regulations 2016	State
Port Management Act 1995	State
Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act (POCTA) 1986	State
POCTA Regulations 2019	State
Public Health and Wellbeing Act 2008 (Vic) and Public Health and Wellbeing Regulations 2019	State
Sale of Land Act 1962	State
Seafood Safety Act 2003	State
Stock (Seller Liability and Declarations Act) 199	State
Traditional Owner Settlement Act 2010	State
Wildlife Act 1975	State
Wildlife Regulations 2013	State

Appendix 12.2 Glossary

Refer to the SEMP for a detailed list of emergency management terms and definitions used in Victoria.

TERM	DESCRIPTION
Animal Health Australia (AHA)	An independent national animal health body in Australia that brings together government and industry to coordinate advocacy and development of programs to support Australia's animal health and biosecurity systems. AHA is represented by 34 organisations from Commonwealth, state and territory governments, livestock industries, service providers and associate members.
AQUAVETPLAN	Australian Aquatic Veterinary Emergency Plan – the national contingency planning framework for the management of aquatic pest and disease emergencies in Australia.
AUSVETPLAN	Australian Veterinary Emergency Plan – the national contingency planning framework for the management of animal pest and disease emergencies in Australia.
Biodiversity	The variability among living organisms from all sources including inter alia terrestrial, marine and other aquatic ecosystems and the ecological complexes of which they are part; this includes diversity within species, between species and of ecosystems.
Biosecurity	The protection of the economy, environment and human health from the negative impacts associated with entry, establishment or spread of exotic pests (including weeds) and diseases.
Biosecurity Incident Management System (BIMS)	The agreed national incident management system for biosecurity incidents. It is based on established incident management systems such as the Australasian Inter-Service Incident Management System (AIIMS).
Case Officer	A Case Officer is a person employed by DEECA who will be appointed to act as a single point of contact to support information flow between the department and an affected producer or producers. The number of producers for whom they Case Officer will act as the point of contact will depend on the scale and complexity of the incident.
Chief Technical Officer (CTO)	The Chief Veterinary Officer (CVO), the Chief Plant Health Officer (CPHO), or their equivalent.
Consultative Committee	A national committee of technical representatives from Affected Parties which strategically directs (and monitors progress of) the technical aspects of the response. These are often referred to by their acronyms which include: CCEAD, CCEPP, NBMCC and CCIMPE.
Containment	Application of quarantine measures in and around an infested / infected area to prevent the further spread of a pest or disease.
Control Area	A legally declared area around the Restricted Area in which the conditions applying are of lesser intensity than those in the Restricted Area (the limits of a Control Area and the conditions applying to it can be varied according to need).
Control Measures	The collective term used to describe the eradication, containment or suppression of a pest or disease.

Cost Sharing	The process of government and industry jointly funding the costs arising from the implementation of a Response Plan. Described in the emergency response deeds.
Delimiting surveillance	Surveillance conducted to establish the boundaries of an area considered to be infested/infected by or free from a pest or disease.
Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (DAFF)	Australian Government department established on in July 2022. Previously known as the Department of Agriculture, Water and the Environment (DAWE). The department enhances Australia's agriculture, unique environment, heritage and water resources through regulation and partnership.
Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action (DEECA)	DEECA brings together Victoria's energy, environment, water, agriculture, forestry, resources, climate action and emergency management functions into a single department. DEECA has a range of responsibilities in mitigation, response, and recovery. These are further outlined here: https://www.emv.vic.gov.au/responsibilities/state-emergency-management-plan-semp/roles-and-responsibilities/role-statements/role-statement-department-of-energy-environment-and-climate-action
Emergency Animal Disease Response Agreement (EADRA)	A contractual arrangement between Animal Health Australia, the Commonwealth, all state and territory governments and national animal industry body signatories (23 in total). It covers the management and funding of responses to 66 categorised animal diseases, including the potential for owner reimbursement costs. It also formalises the role of animal industries' participation in decision making, as well as their contribution towards the costs related to approved responses.
Emergency Management Commissioner (EMC)	The EMC provides leadership for emergency management in Victoria. During a major emergency, the EMC has an overarching role to ensure that the response and recovery is coordinated, and control arrangements are in place. EMC has responsibility for coordination before, during and after major emergencies, including consequence management, as defined in the Emergency Management Act 2013.
Emergency Management Victoria (EMV)	EMV is a central body for emergency management in Victoria. EMV acts as the agency responsible for the coordination of the development of whole-of-government policy for emergency management in Victoria. Further details about the functions of EMV can be found here: https://www.emv.vic.gov.au/responsibilities/state-emergency-management-plan-semp/roles-and-responsibilities/role-statements/role-statement-emergency-management-victoria
Emergency Marine Pest Plan (EMPPLAN)	Rapid Response Manuals for marine pests provide detailed information and guidance for emergency response to key marine pest species or groups of pest species.
Emergency Plant Pest Response Deed (EPPRD)	A legal agreement between Plant Health Australia, the Commonwealth, all state and territory governments and national plant industry body (including bees) signatories (49 in total). It covers the management and funding of responses to emergency plant pest (EPP) incidents, including the potential for owner reimbursement costs for growers. It also formalises the role of plant industries' participation in decision making, as well as their contribution towards the costs related to approved responses.

Emergency Recovery Victoria (ERV)	The nominated agency in Victoria for the coordination of relief at the State tier, and recovery coordination at both Regional and State tiers.
Emergency Response Deeds	Pre-agreed cost sharing and response framework for dealing with an incursion of an emergency animal or plant pest or disease and biosecurity incidents that impact on the economy, the environment and/or social amenity.
Eradication	The elimination of a pest or disease from a geographic area (or production system) that is sufficiently isolated to prevent re-establishment.
Established Pests and Diseases	Pests and diseases affecting plants or animals, including humans, that are known to occur in a particular country or region.
Exotic Pests and Diseases	Pests and diseases affecting plants or animals (and possibly humans) that do not normally occur in a particular country or region.
Forward Command Post	A field operations centre, subsidiary to a Local Disease Control Centre.
Host	A plant or animal species that, under certain conditions, is capable of sustaining a pest, disease or infectious agent.
Incursion	An isolated occurrence of a pest or disease recently detected in an area, not known to be established, but expected to survive for the immediate future.
Infected Premises (IP)	Premises (or locality) at which an emergency pest or disease is confirmed or believed to exist; or in the case of animals an infective agent of that emergency disease. Infected premises are subject to quarantine served by notice and to control measures.
Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity (IGAB)	An agreement between the Australian and state and territory governments. It aims to strengthen partnership between Australian governments and improve the national biosecurity system by outlining agreed national goals and objectives, clarifies roles, responsibilities and governance arrangements and sets out commitments for the Australian Government, and state/territory governments.
International Plant Protection Convention (IPPC)	An intergovernmental treaty signed by over 180 countries, aiming to protect the world's plant resources from the spread and introduction of pests, and promoting safe trade. Its main objectives are to: • ensure transparency of the global plant health situation • set standards that support the safe trade in plants and plant products • provide expertise and encourage international cooperation in the control of plant pests and diseases
Local Control Centre	The operations centre from which all field operations aimed at containing and eradicating the pest or disease are managed. (Is the equivalent to Incident Control Centre in the AIMS structure).
Monitoring and Surveillance	Activities to investigate the presence or prevalence of a pest or disease in a given plant or animal population and its environment.
National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement (NEBRA)	A legal agreement between the Commonwealth and state and territory governments. It covers emergency response arrangements, including cost-sharing arrangements, for responding to biosecurity

	incidents that primarily impact the environment and/or social amenity and where the response is for the public good.
National Management Group (NMG)	A group chaired by the Secretary of DAFF Membership comprises senior officials from the Australian, state and territory governments and industry. The group is responsible in biosecurity emergencies for endorsing the response plan and budget.
Outbreak	A recently detected pest or disease, including an incursion or a sudden significant increase of an established pest population in an area (for example, Australian plague locusts).
Pest Free Area	An area in which a specific pest or disease does not occur as demonstrated by scientific evidence, and in which, where appropriate, this condition is being officially maintained.
Plant Health Australia (PHA)	Plant Health Australia is the national coordinator of the government-industry partnership for plant biosecurity in Australia, that minimises pest impacts on Australia, enhances market access and contributes to industry and community sustainability. PHA membership includes the Commonwealth, all state and territory governments, 39 peak industry bodies and 10 associate members.
PLANTPLAN	Australian Emergency Plant Pest Response Plan – the national contingency planning framework for the management of plant pest emergencies in Australia.
Quarantine	1. The system of measures which are used to manage risks of the entry and establishment of pests and diseases which threaten animal, plant or human health. 2. The act of issuing a legally enforceable quarantine notice to restrict the exit or removal of things that could spread pests or diseases from premises specified in the notice.
Recovery	The assisting of persons and communities affected by emergencies to achieve a proper and effective level of functioning. (Emergency Management Act 2013 section 3)
Relief	Provision of assistance to meet essential needs of individuals, families, and communities during and in the aftermath of an emergency.
Response Plan	An integrated plan, developed by the Chief Technical Officer of one or more states or territories that: outlines the strategic response to a specific emergency pest or disease outbreak; is endorsed by the consultative committee and approved by the NMG; and which is subject to cost sharing in accordance with the relevant emergency response deed.
Restricted Area	A relatively small, declared area (compared to a Control Area) around infected premises that is subject to intense surveillance and movement controls.
Restricted Area Movement Controls	Establishment of control over the movement of animals, animal products, plants, plant products, vehicles, other things and people into, within and out of the restricted area/s, in order to limit the spread of the pest or disease.

State Biosecurity Operations Centre	The emergency operations centre established at a state level, that coordinates the disease or pest control operations to be undertaken in that state or territory.
State Controller Biosecurity (SCB)	Level 3 response: The role responsible for leading and managing responses to a Class 2 Level 3 biosecurity emergency. Ensures effective operational management of the State Control Centre functions that relate to a biosecurity emergency and functional management between the State Biosecurity Operations Centre (when activated) and the State Control Centre. Level 2 response: The State Controller Biosecurity leads the State Biosecurity Operations Centre to implement the pest/disease control strategy and policy, develops state level objectives and priorities for the response, and oversees the coordination of the activities of Local Control Centre(s).
Suppression	The application of movement restrictions and other disease control measures in an infected area to reduce pest populations or disease spread.
Tracing	The process of locating animals, animal products, plants, plant products, vehicles, people, or things which may be implicated in the spread of an emergency pest or disease.
World Organisation for Animal Health (OIE)	The World Organisation of Animal Health (OIE) is an inter-governmental organisation. Its main objectives are to: • ensure transparency of the global disease situation • set standards that support the safe trade in animals and animal products • provide expertise and encourage international cooperation in the control of animal diseases • improve the legal framework and resources of national veterinary services
Zoonosis (or Zoonotic Disease)	Any disease or infection which is naturally transmissible from animals to humans.



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